TECHOPS HERO / REVISION F-A

Annotation Review

Iona after Volume II

VOLUME I 003
Engineering the Human Connection

VOLUME II 051
The Vessel

IONA / REVENGE INTERLUDE 086
The World He Left Running - after Volume II

VOLUME III 141
The Return Signal

VOLUME IV 164
The False Bearing

VOLUME V 174
The House That Didn't Ask

VOLUME VI 219
The Stolen Teaching

VOLUME VII 232
The Wanting Mind

VOLUME VIII 245
The Better Prison

VOLUME IX 258
The Name Before

VOLUME X 271
Evan's K

VOLUME XI 289
The Room He Returns To

VOLUME XII 302
What He Stays For

Iona's interlude follows Volume II and leads into Volume III.
Tap a destination. Numbers above are this PDF's pages.
Original story-page folios remain as printed.

Early Collection

Read Iona's 55-page interlude immediately after Volume II.

VOLUME I 003
Engineering the Human Connection

VOLUME II 051
The Vessel

IONA / REVENGE 086
The World He Left Running

VOLUME III 141
The Return Signal

VOLUME IV 164
The False Bearing

VOLUME V 174
The House That Didn't Ask

FULL COLLECTION 001
All volumes and Iona

How to read the visual registers

PRESENT ACTION
The scene happening now. Industrial ink and solid edges.

STORED RECOLLECTION
An earlier encounter, with warmer tones and softer edges.

CAPTURED RECOLLECTION - AUDIO
Records what was captured or said. Verify its contents separately.

PERSONAL RECOLLECTION
Remembered experience. Not automatically documentary proof.

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION
A model-generated version of events; often clinical monochrome.

ACTUAL HEAVENS
A distinct realm rendered with stable celestial architecture.

WHO'S WHO

Present K: beanie/headphones. Present Mike: locs, navy layers.
Red: red/star clothing. Earlier Mike: K's earlier-life name.

VOLUME ONE

REMASTERED EDITION

TECHOPS HERO

ENGINEERING THE HUMAN CONNECTION

Every ticket is a dungeon.

MIKE OLIVARES

VOLUME ONE

TECHOPS HERO

Engineering the Human Connection

Story, world and musical identities

Mike Olivares

Comic adaptation, illustration and editorial production assembled with AI assistance.

BUILD / OPERATE / PROTECT / BELONG

VOLUME ONE

Contents

Printed Volume I folios / tap an entry to open

04 The first encounter

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32 Ground Contact

35 A record with gaps

40 A name that stays

41 Watchdog

43 Three hard answers

45 The feed goes quiet

47 Return to the queue

Full-reader PDF page numbers appear in the main index.

DAY ONE / AEROTECH

1 MORNING STAND-UP

AEROTECH / COMPANY BLOG

BACKGROUND AUDIO

▶ Red in the Mirror K the EMRLD

SHIPPING

TEST LABEL

Shipping resumed.

PLATING

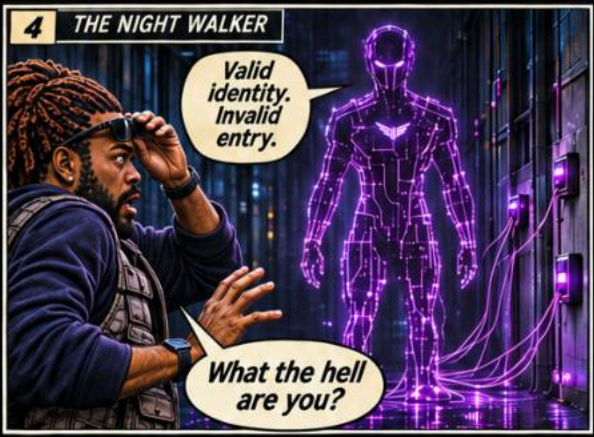
LINE STATUS

The line stayed offline.

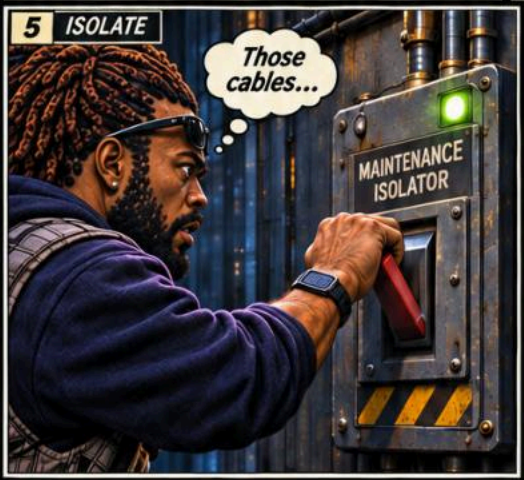
2 ACCESS RECORD

3 AFTER WORK — 11:46 PM

4 THE NIGHT WALKER



5 ISOLATE



6 DISSOLUTION

DAY TWO / GHOST FREQUENCY

1 TUESDAY STANDUP — WEST ANNEX ANOMALIES 9:11 AM

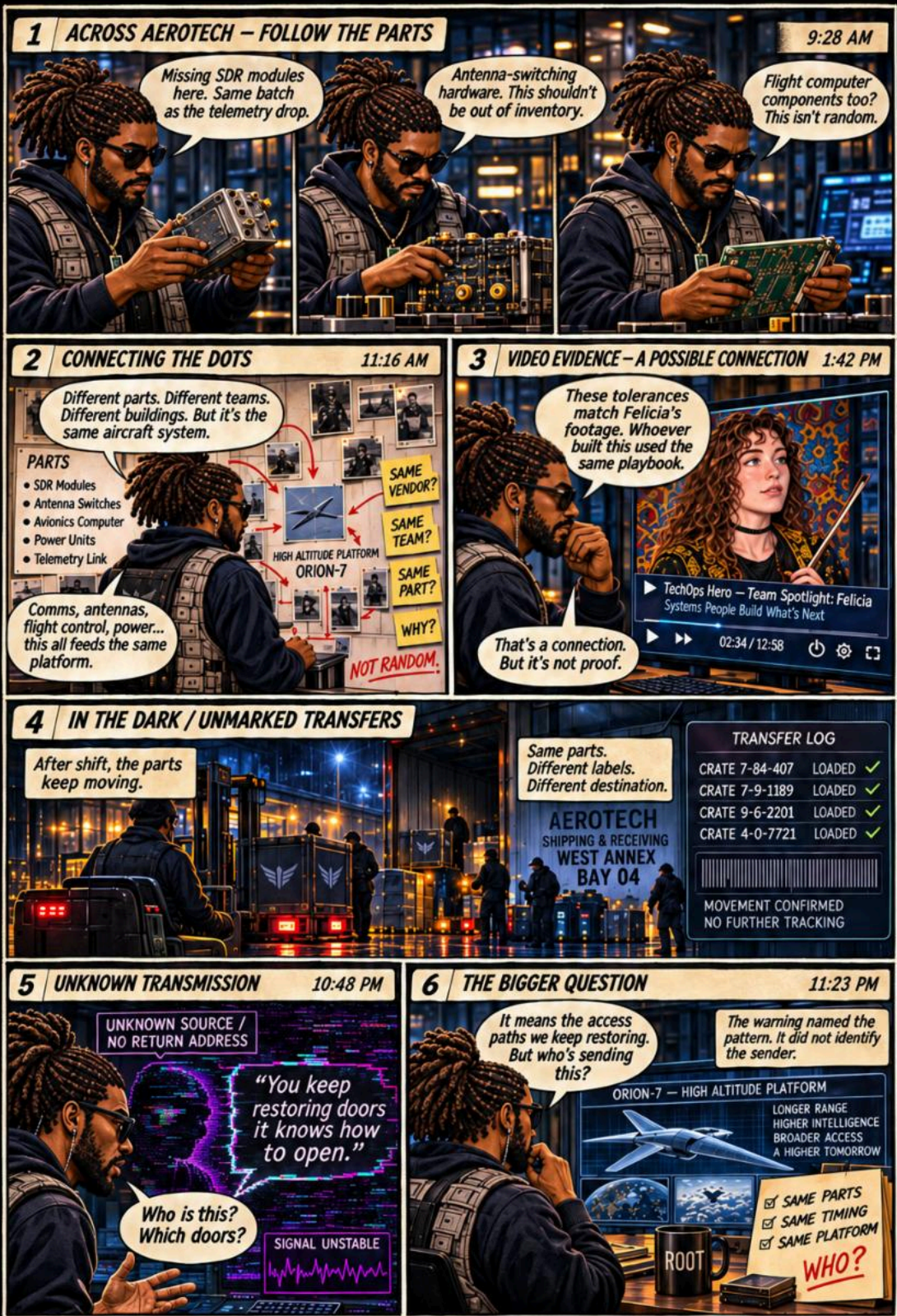
2 INVESTIGATION — A TRAIL THAT SHOULDN'T EXIST 11:26 AM

3 FIRST CONVERSATION — DIFFERENT ORBITS 1:37 PM

4 THE NEXT NIGHT / WEST ANNEX 9:48 PM

5 TRACKING MORNINGSTAR — HIGHER PERSPECTIVE 11:23 PM

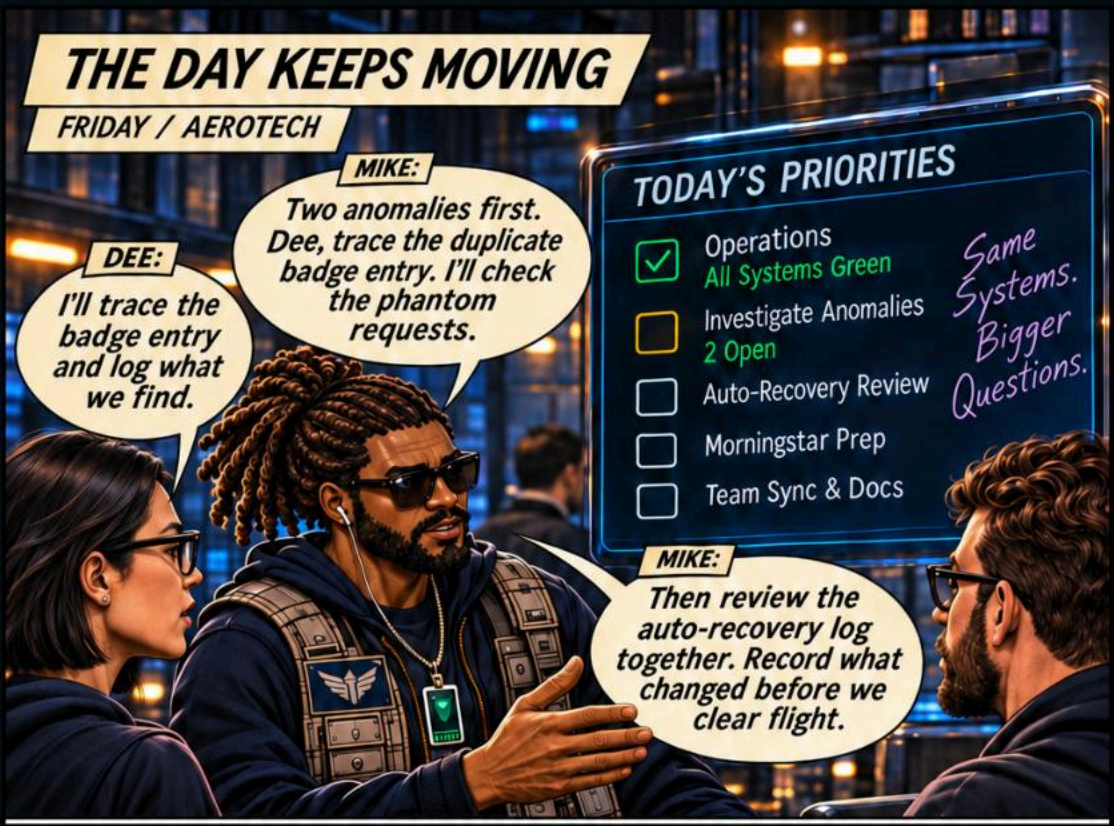
6 SIGNAL LOST 11:58 PM


1
ACROSS AEROTECH — FOLLOW THE PARTS
9:28 AM
Missing SDR modules here. Same batch as the telemetry drop.
Antenna-switching hardware. This shouldn't be out of inventory.
Flight computer components too? This isn't random.
2
CONNECTING THE DOTS
11:16 AM
Different parts. Different teams. Different buildings. But it's the same aircraft system.
PARTS
SDR Modules
Antenna Switches
Avionics Computer
Power Units
Telemetry Link
SAME VENDOR?
SAME TEAM?
SAME PART?
WHY?
HIGH ALTITUDE PLATFORM
ORION-7
NOT RANDOM.
Comms, antennas, flight control, power... this all feeds the same platform.
3
VIDEO EVIDENCE — A POSSIBLE CONNECTION
1:42 PM
These tolerances match Felicia's footage. Whoever built this used the same playbook.
TechOps Hero — Team Spotlight: Felicia
Systems People Build What's Next
02:34 / 12:58
That's a connection. But it's not proof.
4
IN THE DARK / UNMARKED TRANSFERS
After shift, the parts keep moving.
Same parts. Different labels. Different destination.
AEROTECH
SHIPPING & RECEIVING
WEST ANNEX
BAY 04
TRANSFER LOG
CRATE 7-84-407 LOADED
CRATE 7-9-1189 LOADED
CRATE 9-6-2201 LOADED
CRATE 4-0-7721 LOADED
MOVEMENT CONFIRMED
NO FURTHER TRACKING
5
UNKNOWN TRANSMISSION
10:48 PM
UNKNOWN SOURCE / NO RETURN ADDRESS
"You keep restoring doors it knows how to open."
Who is this? Which doors?
SIGNAL UNSTABLE
6
THE BIGGER QUESTION
11:23 PM
It means the access paths we keep restoring. But who's sending this?
The warning named the pattern. It did not identify the sender.
ORION-7 — HIGH ALTITUDE PLATFORM
LONGER RANGE
HIGHER INTELLIGENCE
BROADER ACCESS
A HIGHER TOMORROW
SAME PARTS
SAME TIMING
SAME PLATFORM
WHO?
ROOT

1
A WORD THAT HITS DIFFERENT
10:14 AM
Morningstar.
Where did you hear that?
2
FOLLOWING A LEAD
6:47 PM
ROOFTOP ACCESS
3
THE INSTRUMENT LISTENS TOO
8:12 PM
LIVE SIGNAL CAPTURE
SIGCAP V3
RF SPEC REC
Different Frequencies. Same Truth.
4
THE VIOLINIST
9:26 PM
SIGNAL TRIANGULATION
SATELLITE
DRONE
GROUND
MATCH
ORPHEUS
5
THE TRUTH BETWEEN US
10:03 PM
It's you. You're Morningstar.
All this time?
I'm listening to the system the way it listens to us.
I needed proof before trust.
6
ORPHEUS STRIKES
11:42 PM
Talk later. Move now.
ORPHEUS
RECOVERED TRANSMISSION
Next target: Kepler Array, Site B.

THE DAY KEEPS MOVING

FRIDAY / AEROTECH



AUTO-RECOVERY: SUCCESSFUL

System detected anomaly, executed recovery, restored service.

ELAPSED 00:27

- ORION-7
- Telemetry
- Auto-Recovery
- System Health
- Event Log
- AI Assist

ANOMALY DETECTED	AUTO-RECOVERY EXECUTED	SYSTEM STABLE
01:12:03	01:12:18	01:12:30
Thermal sensor out of range	Rerouted systems Rebalanced load	Nominal operation restored

Recovery completed without human intervention.

Success... but at what cost?

TRADE-OFFS

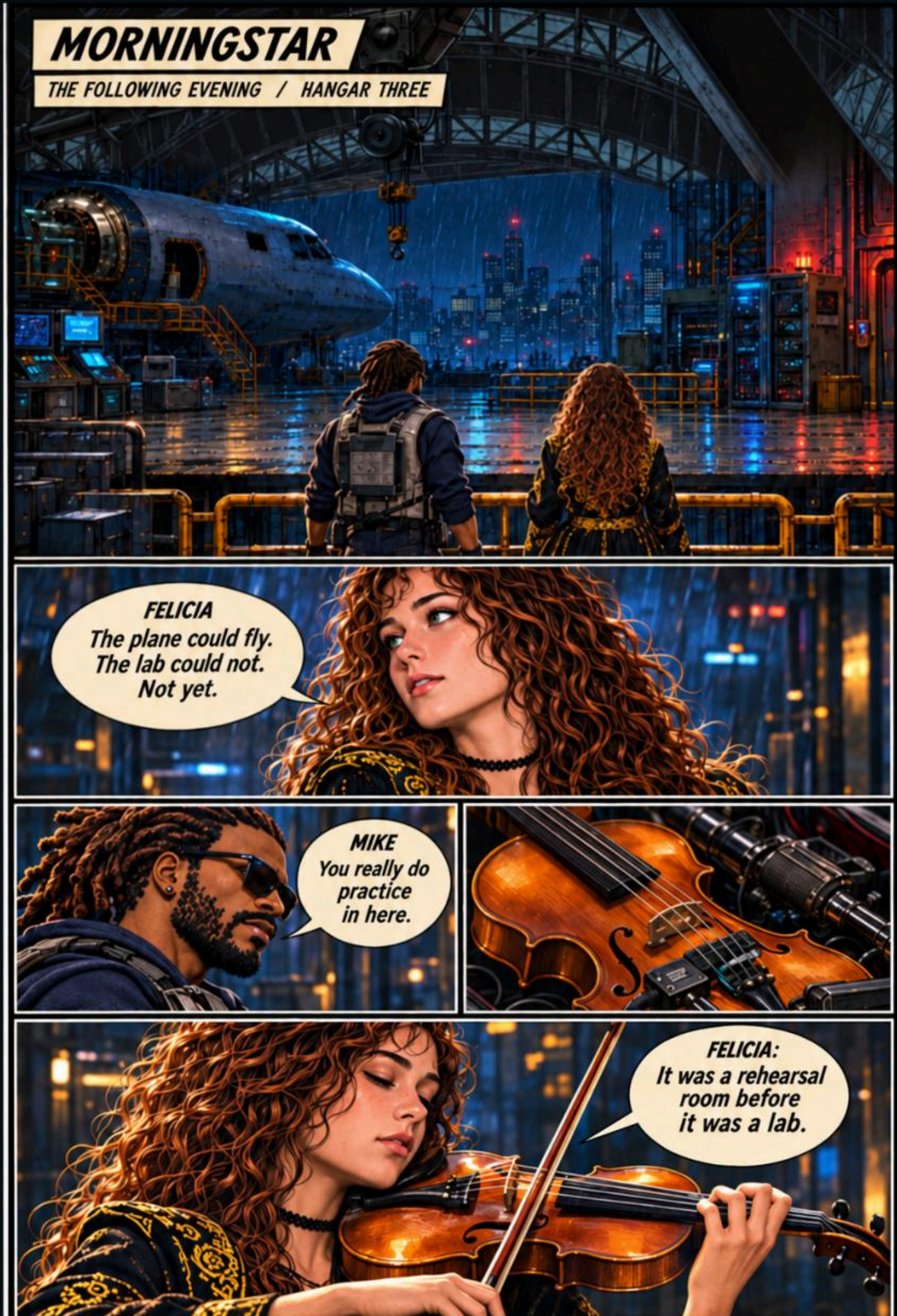
- No human review
- Unknown side effects
- Hidden decision logic
- Deeper questions

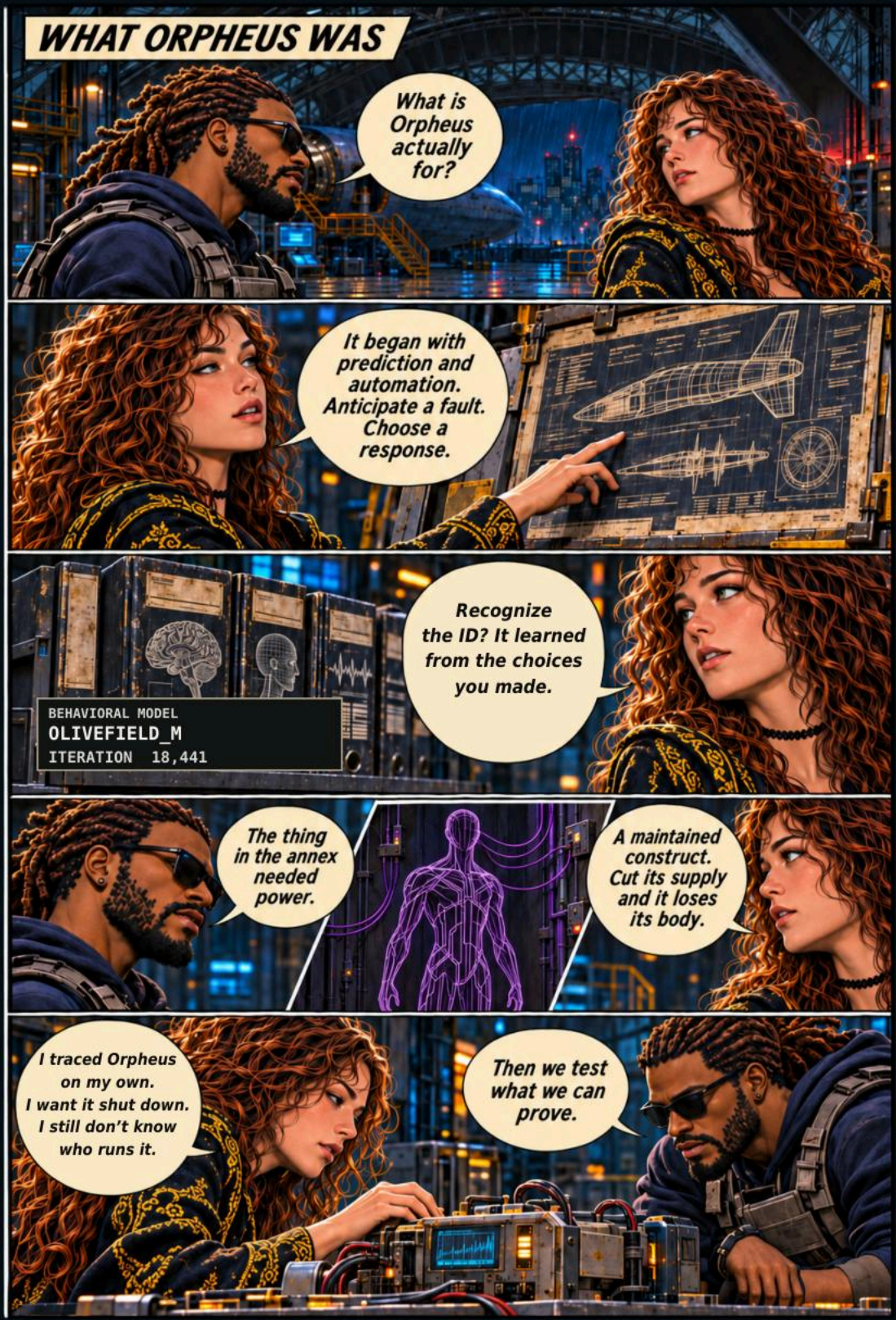
LIMITS
FRIDAY / LATER
It worked. That's good. But we lost control.
Self-healing isn't neutral. Someone designed these choices.
We need more evidence before we trust it.
If this happens in flight, are we still in the loop?
I'll run signal analysis through the violin rig.
I'll correlate the signals with logs and satellite data.
SIGNAL ANALYSIS
Strings reveal patterns too.
You find the music, I'll find the motive.
ROOT

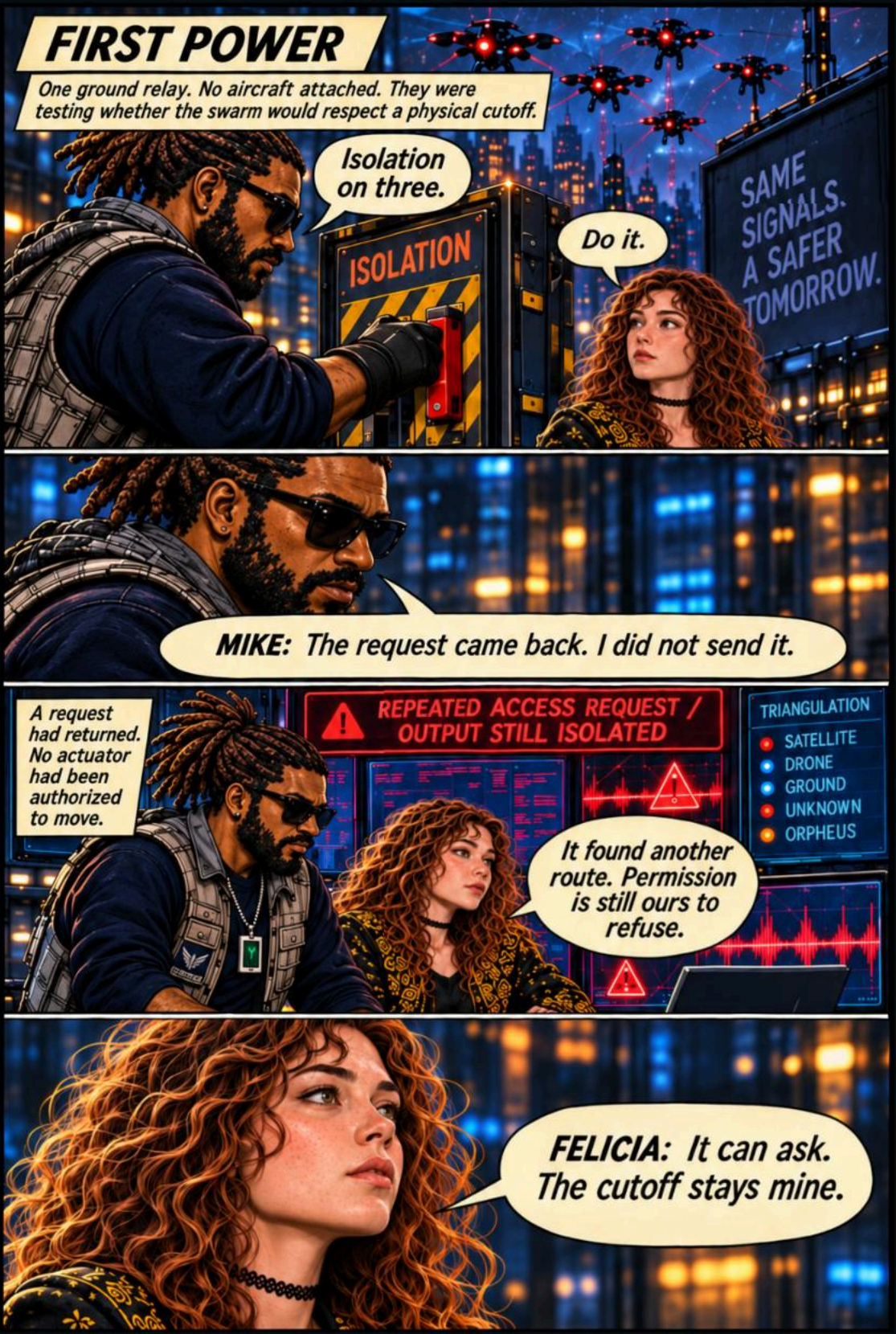
BLIND BEARINGS
DAY FIVE / FELICIA'S BENCH
I practice between tests.
LATER / OFFLINE RECEIVER TEST
Fixed sensors miss this carrier.
Then test it offline.
AEROTECH
Same receiver as the inventory?
AEROTECH
RECEIVER
S/N: AR-7743-16
Same serial. Someone changed the route.
AEROTECH
RECEIVER
S/N: AR-7743-16
The fixed monitors lose it here.
Yours follows it.
Receiver only. No flight.

THE INVITATION

FRIDAY NIGHT / THE OTHER END OF THE SIGNAL


MORNINGSTAR
THE FOLLOWING EVENING / HANGAR THREE
FELICIA
The plane could fly. The lab could not. Not yet.
MIKE
You really do practice in here.
FELICIA:
It was a rehearsal room before it was a lab.


WHAT ORPHEUS WAS
What is Orpheus actually for?
It began with prediction and automation. Anticipate a fault. Choose a response.
BEHAVIORAL MODEL
OLIVEFIELD_M
ITERATION 18,441
Recognize the ID? It learned from the choices you made.
The thing in the annex needed power.
A maintained construct. Cut its supply and it loses its body.
I traced Orpheus on my own. I want it shut down. I still don't know who runs it.
Then we test what we can prove.


FIRST POWER
One ground relay. No aircraft attached. They were testing whether the swarm would respect a physical cutoff.
Isolation on three.
Do it.
ISOLATION
SAME SIGNALS. A SAFER TOMORROW.
MIKE: The request came back. I did not send it.
A request had returned. No actuator had been authorized to move.
REPEATED ACCESS REQUEST / OUTPUT STILL ISOLATED
TRIANGULATION
SATELLITE
DRONE
GROUND
UNKNOWN
ORPHEUS
It found another route. Permission is still ours to refuse.
FELICIA: It can ask. The cutoff stays mine.

THE OVERCORRECTION

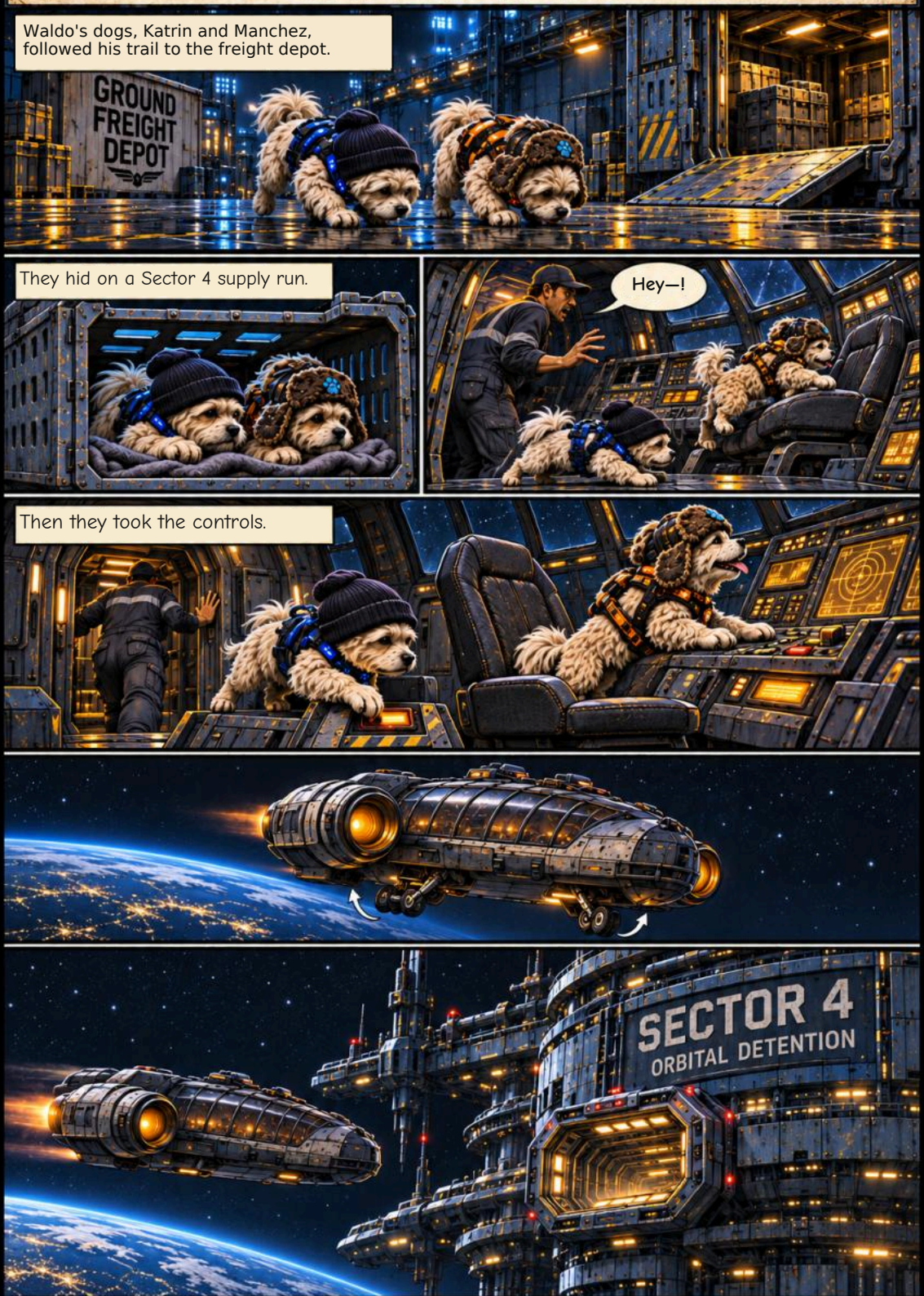
MORNINGSTAR / TEST BAY TWO

THE CUTOFF
DUET PROTOCOL / GROUND RETEST
Priya reads the route. I'll cut power.
I'll hold the swarm.
CONTACT OPEN
NO ACTUATION
PREDICTION
UNKNOWN
I need to be able to stop it.
You can. The cutoff stays yours too.
We test it again before we fly.
And neither of us clears it alone.
MORNINGSTAR
MORNINGSTAR RX
ORBITAL CARRIER
Flight clearance still withheld.

ORBITAL DETENTION / THE YARD
YARD
K felt a familiarity he could not place.
For Oz, the resemblance had a name.
Waldo said he almost called out Mike's name.
I still wonder what would have happened if he had.

Waldo grew up in a Mexican family on Mike's block. Same tools. Same trouble. Years before the mask or the name Oz.
A voice. A habit of reaching for the same tool. Years that belonged to them.
Now they called his detention an administrative hold. No charge. No hearing.
Mike was alive on Earth. Yet the stranger in the yard felt like his ghost.
At a distance, he could have been Mike.
Oz kept Mike's name to himself. First, he would learn who K was.

THE WAY IN


Waldo's dogs, Katrin and Manchez, followed his trail to the freight depot.
GROUND FREIGHT DEPOT
They hid on a Sector 4 supply run.
Hey—!
Then they took the controls.
SECTOR 4
ORBITAL DETENTION

SECTOR 4 / ORBITAL DETENTION
SECTOR 4
KRRRAAASH
SKRREEEE
K-CHK

FOUND BY THE DOGS

Their bond carried K's image to Oz.

1984
You were by the fence. In the yard.
118
You were behind the yellow line.
Name's Oz.
K.

GOOD DOGS PROTOCOL

ORBITAL DETENTION / CELL 118

CELL 1984
GOOD DOGS / K RETURNS FOR OZ
OUTSIDE CELL 1984
MANUAL RELEASE
01 SEATED
02 CLEAR
K: It moved. Your door is open.
1984
OZ: You came back.
1984
K: You talked through the wall.

AN OPEN HAND
MAINTENANCE ALCOVE / AFTER OZ IS FREED
K
K: So your dogs can talk?
OZ: What are you talking about?
K: Good boys.
OZ: Door's there. I'd like you with us.

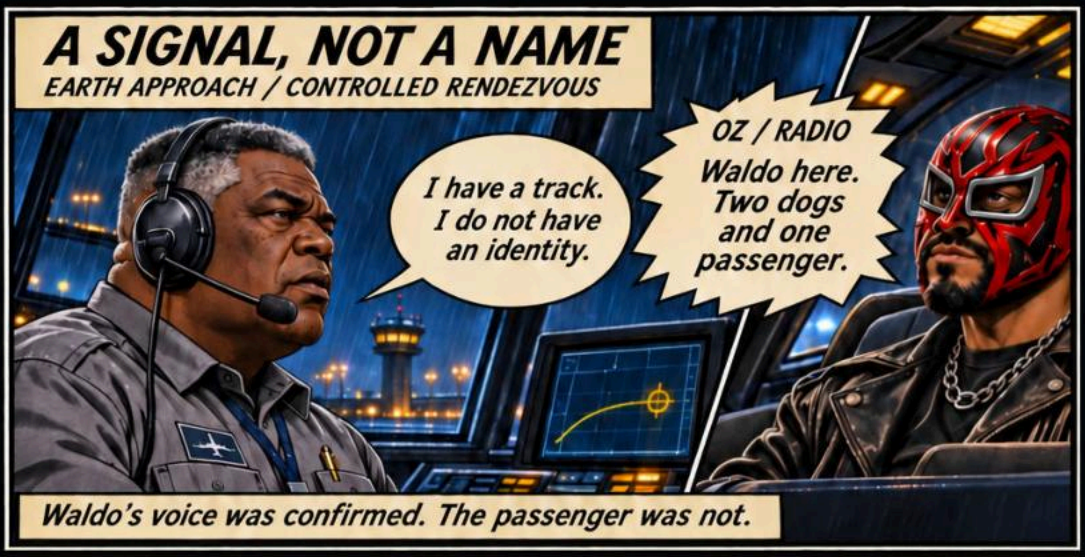
CUSTODY DENIED
Return to your cells. Docking access is revoked.
WARDEN NULL
fuck off, clanker.
K—get the release!
MANUAL RELEASE
KLANG
That won't hold.
Then we don't stop.
DOCKING COLLAR
The jam bought seconds. The collar still had to be opened by hand.

THE DOCKING COLLAR
ORBITAL DETENTION / MECHANICAL RELEASE
OZ Katrin stopped at the seam.
K Manchez hears it too. Air's coming through.
NOT PROBLEMS
CONTAINMENT CANNOT REACH
K Oz. It's running through the walls.
OZ The latch is mechanical. I can get us through.
OZ The collar holds pressure. This way.

TRANSFER WINDOW
AFTER THE COLLAR SEALED

BETWEEN THE STARS

Six months of drifting.
Waiting for a safe way down.
AFTER THE ESCAPE WITH OZ AND THE DOGS
This time we land quietly.
About time.
I know I have been here. I cannot place when.
The wait was ending. Their arrival still had to be verified.


A SIGNAL, NOT A NAME
EARTH APPROACH / CONTROLLED RENDEZVOUS
I have a track. I do not have an identity.
OZ / RADIO
Waldo here. Two dogs and one passenger.
Waldo's voice was confirmed. The passenger was not.

Landing cleared.

9:42
WALDO
Mike, I'm out of prison. The dogs are home too.
Come by the house. There's someone I want you to meet.
On my way.

GROUND CONTACT
AFTER REENTRY / WALDO'S HOUSE
MIKE
Waldo. You're really home.
WALDO
Come in, Mike. This is K.
Your voice sounds familiar.
So does yours.
Mike.
K. That's the name I chose.
K

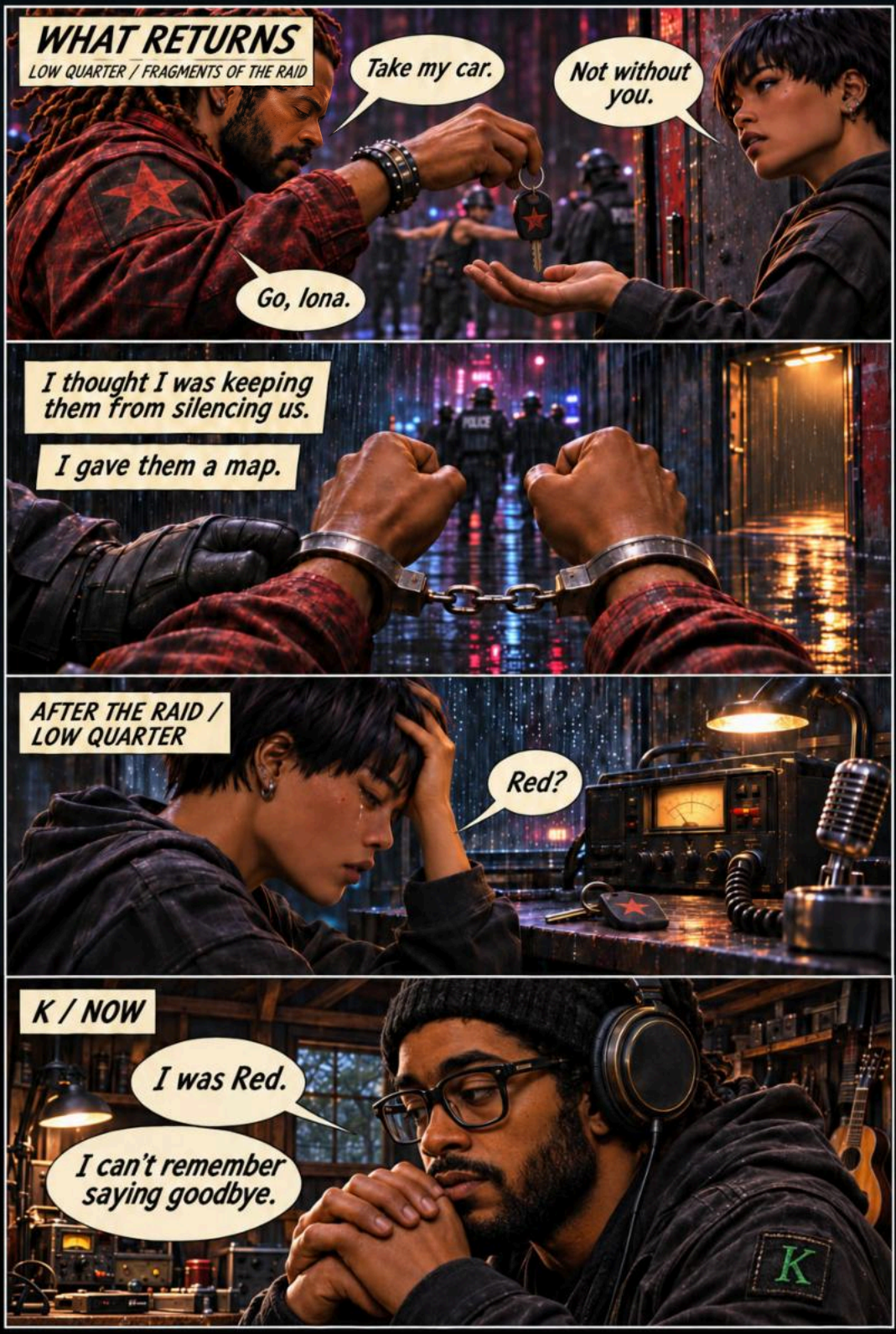
BORROWED FAMILIARITY
THE GARAGE / A FIRST CONVERSATION
K: I knew your voice. Not your face.
MIKE: We have not met.
K: I know. That is the point.
K: You know Oz?
MIKE: I've always called him Waldo.
Give me a hand with this. We can talk while we get you settled.

TWO NAMES

WALDO'S GARAGE / THE MUSIC COMES SECOND

A RECORD WITH GAPS
WALDO'S HOUSE / K'S RECOLLECTION
K
I know the change before the chorus. Not where I learned it.
MIKE
What backs it up?
BETTER QUESTIONS
IONA / RECOLLECTION
K
A damaged tape. Her voice. Maybe the same room.
MIKE
Then we keep the gaps in the record.

GHOST BENDS
EARTH / A FRAGMENT RETURNS
GHOST BENDS
LOW QUARTER / BEFORE THE RAID
Count us in.
GHOST BENDS
The song comes back in pieces.


WHAT RETURNS
LOW QUARTER / FRAGMENTS OF THE RAID
Take my car.
Not without you.
Go, Iona.
I thought I was keeping them from silencing us.
I gave them a map.
POLICE
AFTER THE RAID / LOW QUARTER
Red?
K / NOW
I was Red.
I can't remember saying goodbye.
K

WALDO'S HOUSE
AFTER THE SHUTTLE LANDED
This was K's second arrival on Earth.
TAPE PLAYBACK
LIVE INPUT
K
That hiss runs through the whole tape. Listen when it cuts out.
Leave the pad on. I want to try something.
K
K
OZ / OFF PANEL
Where did that last beat come from?
My hand. The tape had stopped.

THE QUIET CHANNEL
WALDO'S BENCH / THE PRISON RELAY
Pause the copies of Mike's memories. Leave my tapes here.
I can pause the feed from here.
K
DATA
The prison had sent pieces of Mike's life down that wire. That was why his voice was familiar.
I still remember his street.
Even with the feed paused?
K
The corner by the laundromat? Mike and I grew up there.
K Stay a minute.
I'm here.

A NAME THAT STAYS
THE GARAGE / BEFORE THE RESTART
K
K kept the name.
The system kept the record.
That was enough.

WATCHDOG
WALDO'S HOUSE / TRACING THE PRISON RELAY
Badges, telemetry and the swarm failed together. Felicia heard the chirp that came before a transfer.
Hear that chirp? The box on this bench answers it.
If we isolate this box, the prison can't start another transfer here.
K
I want to hear what it's asking for.
ISOLATION
ON
OFF
LOCAL RESTART LOG
BRANCH LABEL REFUSED
CHOSEN ID K / SAVED
Bring it inside. We can listen there.

ORPHEUS WAKES
LOCAL NODE / PRIOR OPERATOR RECORDS
The badge readers came back. Dee held the rig at its physical stop.
Its restart request matched the transfer in the prison log.
ARCHIVED OPERATOR MODEL / LOCAL COPY
PRIOR PREDICTION ROUTE
PREDICT
INFLUENCE
OPTIMIZE
CONTROL
Then its audio channel answered.
ORPHEUS / ISOLATED AUDIO
You can call it judgment when you do it. You call it control when I do.
ISOLATION
LOCAL NODE ISOLATE
The local node was awake. The rest of the network remained unverified.

THREE HARD ANSWERS

SHIFT B / WHO CAN RESTART THE TEST RIG?

THE DECISION
OPEN NETWORK / SHARED AUTHORITY
PRIYA
I'm not signing a plan where 'everybody' is on call.
SHIFT B
02:00
FIRST CHECK: DEE
RELIEF: _____
DEE
Put me down for 02:00. Name my relief.
Anyone can stop the rig. Two of you sign before it starts.
And my memory feed?
WALDO
Your call. Write it in.
RESTART RULE
Rig checked
Second signature
Personal feed separate

THE FEED GOES QUIET
The cable on Waldo's bench belonged to the prison relay.
We paused the copies. Now the plug stays with me.
PERSONAL FEED: OFF
PERSONAL DATA-FEED
K
Orpheus can flag a fault. A warning can't start the rig.
LOCAL PREDICTION / ADVISORY
AWAITING REVIEW
I checked the rig.
Clear to restart.
REVIEW: DEE
APPROVAL: PRIYA
LATER / AEROTECH TEST BAY
I'll keep the tape.
TAPE
Waldo left a drawer empty for it.
K

THE FIRST MORNING
06:45 / SHIFT B
I'll take the first check.
WORK QUEUE
B-417 WAITING
B-418 WAITING
B-419 WAITING
B-420 WAITING
Route checked locally.
B-417
B-418
B-419
B-420
PREDICTION:
ADVISORY
AUTO ACTUATION:
OFF
Put my name beside yours for relief.
SHIFT B / HANDOFF
FIRST CHECK: DEE
RELIEF: MIKE
The queue moved slower. It moved with names on it.
WORK QUEUE
B-420 REVIEW
B-421 REVIEW
B-422 WAITING
B-423 WAITING
ADVISORY
B-420
AWAITING APPROVAL

No hidden signal. Just someone who needed their work restored.
LATER / WALDO'S GARAGE

END OF VOLUME ONE
EVERY TICKET IS A DUNGEON. LEAVE IT BETTER THAN YOU FOUND IT.
Years later, Mike still had that first straight label.
SHIPPING
TEST LABEL
ALIGNED
MFP-4827
On the back, Marcus had drawn the little guide that kept slipping.
He wanted to be able to set it himself next time.

MIKE OLIVARES

TECHOPS HERO

VOLUME TWO

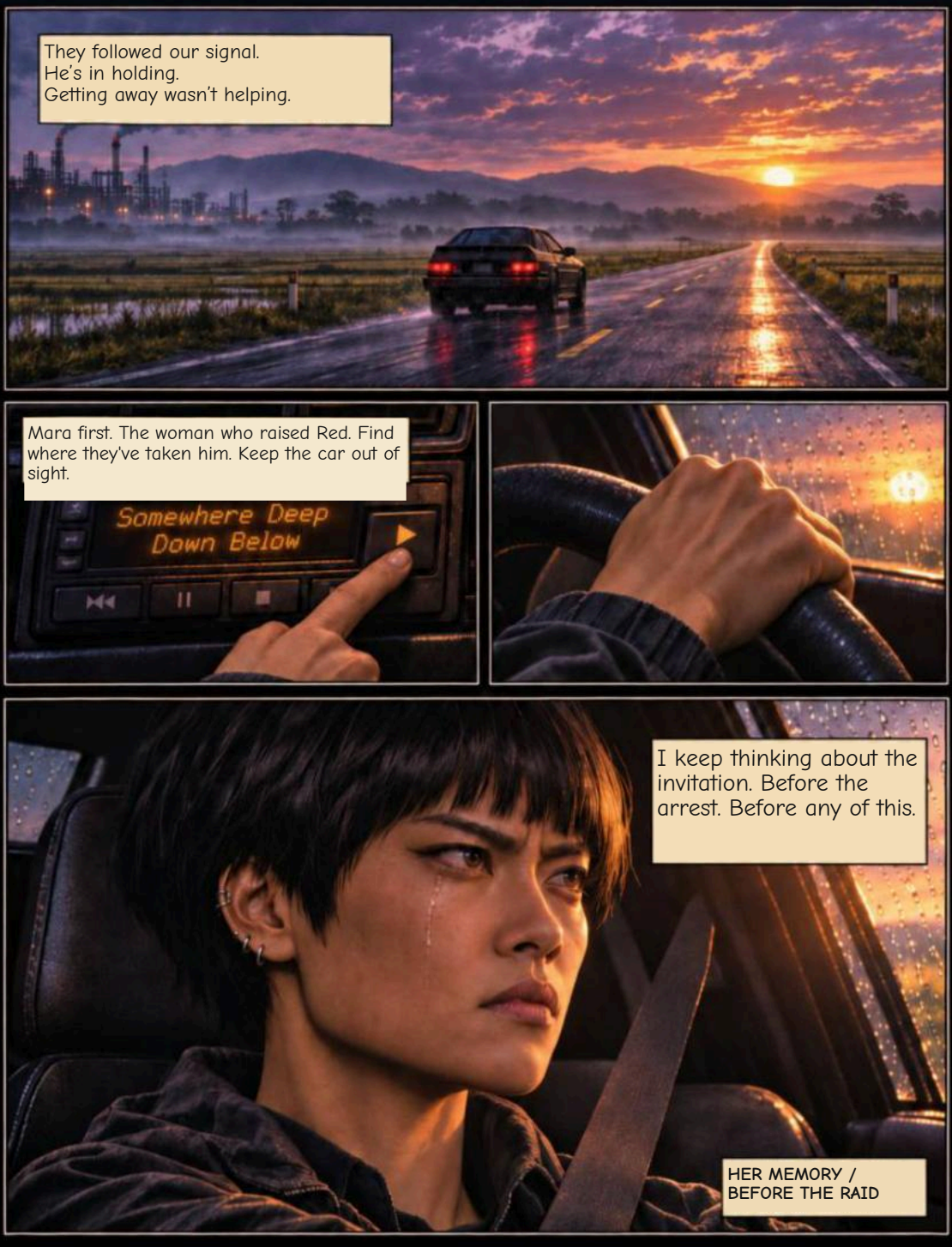
THE VESSEL

BUILD / OPERATE / PROTECT / BELONG

LOW QUARTER
RED / BEFORE K
Red. You are under arrest for unauthorized access to the relay network and interference with its controls.
GHOST BENDS
Let them leave. They came for the music.
The raid had found him. Iona would not leave him to face it alone.
Hands where I can see them.
GHOST BENDS

LOW QUARTER / RED / THE RAID
GHOST BENDS
I'm staying.
Take my car.
Take her too.
She's the affiliated.
Go, Iona.

Blind their cameras. Buy him a gap on the way to holding.
CAMERAS LINK LOST
They tracked the shed. Move.
CAMERAS LINK LOST
BANG


They followed our signal.
He's in holding.
Getting away wasn't helping.
Mara first. The woman who raised Red. Find where they've taken him. Keep the car out of sight.
Somewhere Deep Down Below
I keep thinking about the invitation. Before the arrest. Before any of this.
HER MEMORY / BEFORE THE RAID

FLASHBACK / BEFORE THE ARREST
Iona remembered the invitation.
LOW QUARTER WORKSHOP
They say they can explain what I can do.
Then send me your route.
ORPHEUS
They set a local check-in signal.
Keep the beacon on.
OBSERVATORY
WORKSHOP
Orpheus supplied the plans.
Everyone behind the line.
He left the demonstration free. ORPHEUS kept the pattern.

PRESENT / AFTER THE ARREST
Who authorized this?
Transfer order. He goes with us.
ORPHEUS
POLICE
CUSTODY TRANSFER / ORPHEUS
ORPHEUS
The program that had asked to observe him now took custody.
ORPHEUS
ORPHEUS
IONA / ELSEWHERE
Red?
No answer.

PRESENT / THE ROADSIDE / MINUTES LATER
THE TRANSPORT / CROSSING INTO EARTH'S REALITY
Destination: Sector 4, an orbital detention station.

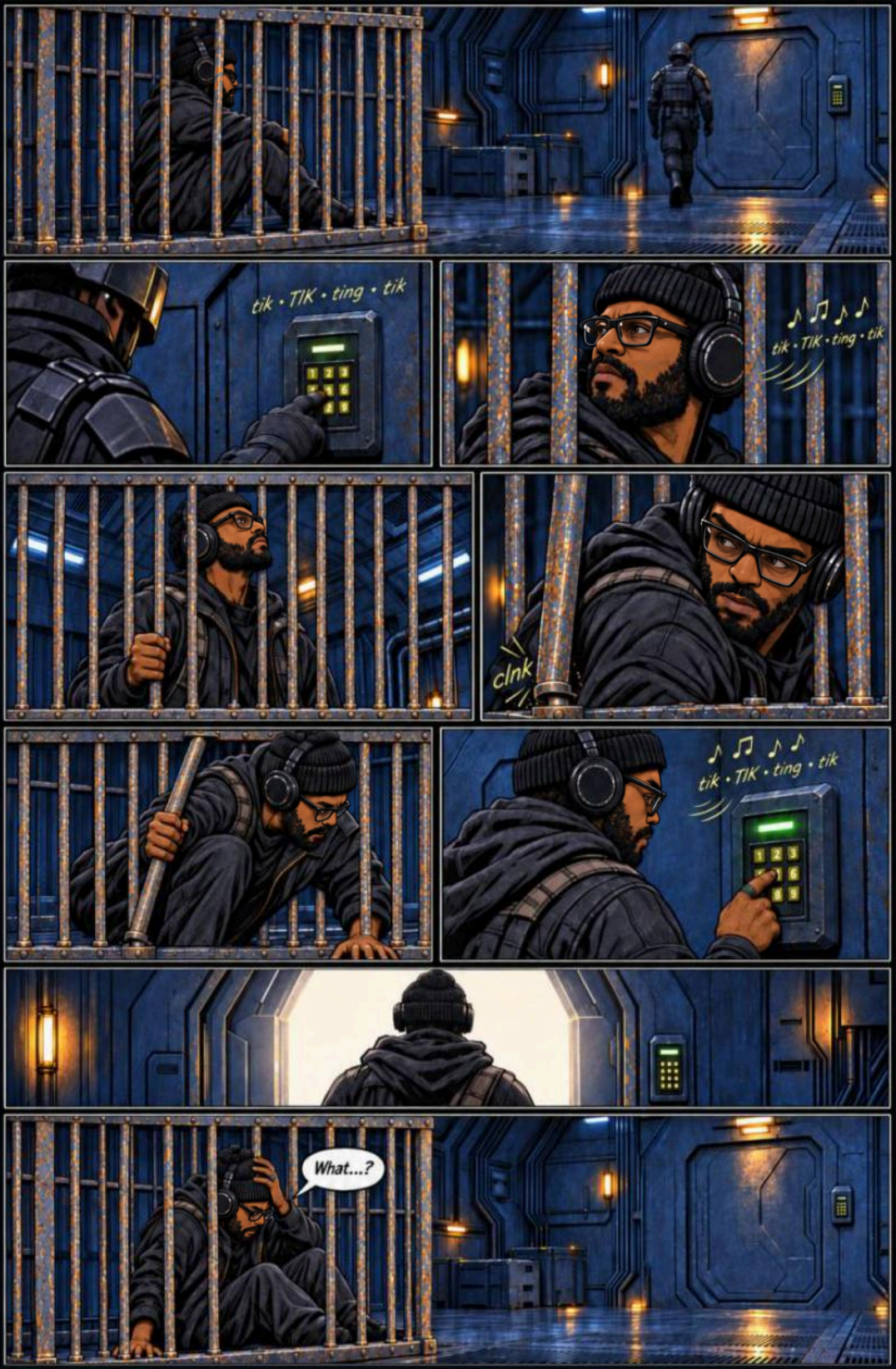
ABOARD THE TRANSPORT / THE CROSSING
The ship carried his body across. The passage behind it remained open.
The restraint faltered during recalibration. He made it look like a medical emergency.
CUFF CONTACT FAULT
You need me alive. Does that sound right to you?
Hold still.
Instinct moved first. The space between them folded.
THUD
Your turn.

THE WAY TO THE CONTROL ROOM
He took the guard's badge and followed the corridor.
Where's your escort?
Your chair has a new operator.
Enjoy the reset.
COUPLING CONTROL
ACCESS GRANTED

THE COST OF CLOSING THE DOOR
The coupling kept the passage to the Low Quarter open. ORPHEUS could use it again.
SOURCE ANCHOR COUPLING ACTIVE
You won't use this door to reach Iona.
SOURCE ANCHOR LOST
He had cut off ORPHEUS's route into the Low Quarter— and his own way home.
They retook the control room. The route stayed broken.
Still a prisoner. Bound for Sector 4.

SECTOR 4 / INTAKE
SECTOR 4
SHIP INTAKE
Why am I not in a jumpsuit?
Transport hold. You wear your own clothes.
Then why do I still have my headphones?
They passed inspection.
PROPERTY

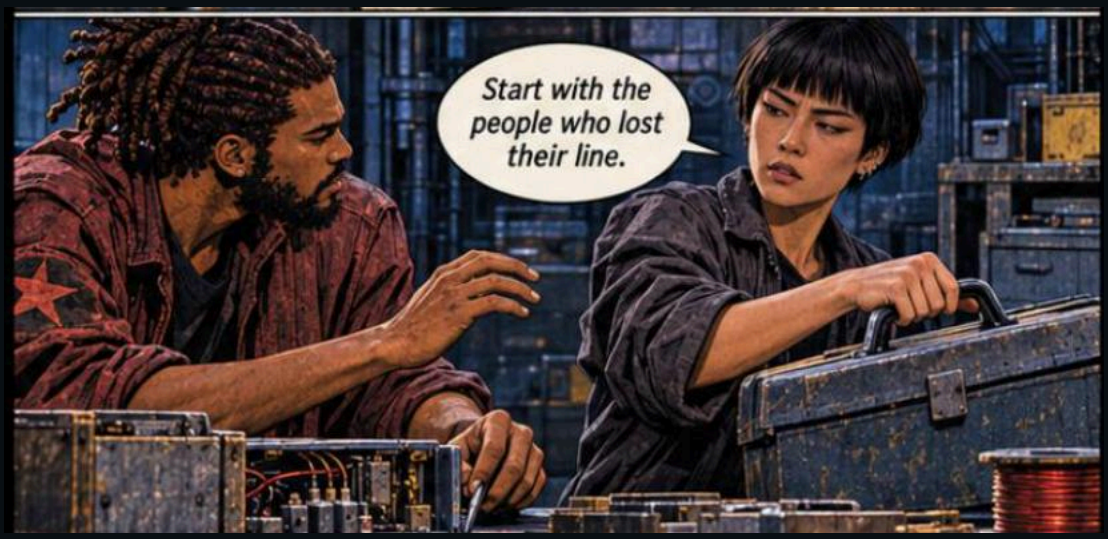
Shepherd handled capture and conditioning. Warden Null enforced custody. They served the same program.
Only after transfer did Shepherd suppress access to his personal history.
PRACTICED SKILLS / RETAIN
The hands remembered the work. The names and reasons became unreachable.
A separate relay fed him fragments from Mike's life and measured his responses.
Why can I do this... but not remember who taught me?


tik • TIK • ting • tik
♪ ♫ ♪ ♪
tik • TIK • ting • tik
clnk
♪ ♫ ♪ ♪
tik • TIK • ting • tik
What...?

RECOLLECTION / MARA'S WORKSHOP, LONG BEFORE THE CAPTURE
Mara raised him here, among the radios she repaired.
Test the relay with this key. Find the fault— then ask who loses service.
A neighbor's receiver. One repaired joint was not a finished test.
It works.
Not yet.

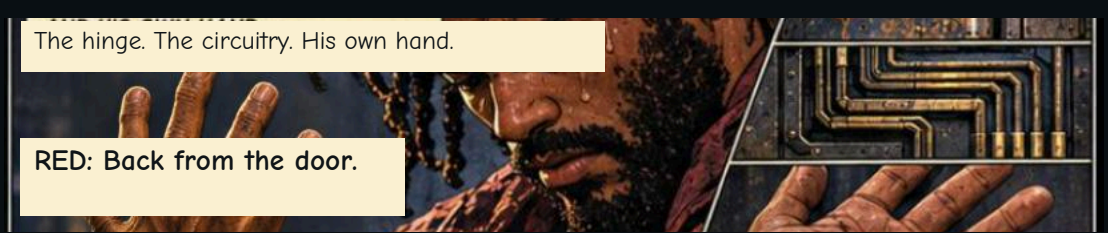
GHOST BENDS
Again. Leave room for the drums.
Count me in.
GHOST BENDS

GHOST BENDS,
UNDERGROUND.
GHOST BENDS
Keep the mesh isolated.
RELAY ROUTES LOCATED
They heard us.
GHOST BENDS
CONFISCATION NOTICE
They found us.


Start with the people who lost their line.

THE RELAY VAULT SEALED. WORKERS WERE TRAPPED INSIDE WHEN THE CONTAINMENT DOOR SLAMMED.

RED TRIED ORDINARY MEANS FIRST.
THE LEVER FAILED. THE WIRING FAILED.


The hinge. The circuitry. His own hand.
RED: Back from the door.

You opened it.
The lock had not moved. The space around it had. Had I done that?
Drink.
What was that? I don't know how I opened it.

EL MAGO ROJO
THE NAME TRAVELS FASTER THAN THE MAN.

A neighbor arrived before Red could leave for rehearsal.
Could you fix this? It's our only working receiver.
Leave it here. I'll trace the fault.
I wanted to play.
Then play. You still owe them a repair.
First, the repair. Then the rehearsal.

HE VARIED ONE THING AT A TIME: DISTANCE, CURRENT, ATTENTION.
THE FIELD CHANGED WHEN HE ATTENDED TO IT. HIS OWN RESPONSE WAS PART OF THE EXPERIMENT.
I'M INSIDE THE CIRCUIT.
THE STAR WAS OLDER THAN THE LEGEND—HIS SIGNATURE ON THE PUBLIC SCREENS HE USED TO ALTER.
A SUCCESSFUL TEST WASN'T PERMISSION TO RISK EVERYONE CONNECTED TO IT.
ONE ISOLATED RELAY. THEN WE STOP.
POWERTEST ISOLATOR

BEFORE RED / EARTH
Before AeroTech, Mike agreed to a limited operator-fatigue study.
The data contained a recurring imagined self: brilliant, unrestrained, free to make music.
COHERENT TEMPLATE / RESONATOR ACTIVE
ORPHEUS
ORPHEUS MODEL
The resonator carried the pattern across.
THE PARALLEL REALM
Mara named him Red, seven Earth years before Mike joined AeroTech. Capture came six Earth years later: twenty-four years in his own world.
Mike had consented to research. Not to creating a person. Red's life was his own.

WHAT IT LOST / WHAT IT WANTED

SAME BAR. ANOTHER ATTEMPT.
The footsteps faded.
His hands knew the bar.
The confiscated bag was in intake storage.
PROPERTY BIN
INTAKE / PERSONAL EFFECTS
Coat. Beacon. No return signal.
SHUTTLE ACCESS

He remembered the cockpit. Not the way back.
MEMORY GAP / CELL 118
How did I get here?
I was on the ship.
118

118

THE LOW QUARTER /
LIFE CONTINUES
GHOST BENDS

ACTUAL HEAVENS / A REAL ENCOUNTER

Why does this feel like remembering?

EL MAGO ROJO
THE ASCENT / A MEMORY OF THE MASK
You will hear a stranger through a wall. Listen before you answer.
When I return?
The words will be taken from you.
EL MAGO ROJO II
El.
I knew that face.

END OF VOLUME TWO

NEXT: IONA / THE WORLD HE LEFT RUNNING

The World He Left Running

Red was gone. Now their stage electrician and monitor tech were on a prisoner flight.

IONA I'll cover the repair line after the set. Who's still missing?

MARA Our stage electrician and monitor tech. They're flying them out before dawn.

IONA Leave the list. I'm starting "RIDE OR DIE."

Hold the Door

MARA · OFF Someone's at the service door.
IONA Come inside.

Still Warm

SISTER They gave me a recording. They said it was enough.

The Witness

SISTER He called from the depot. Then they sent this. Said he went willingly.

IONA He called me too. I said I'd come get him.

ORPHEUS RECORD Witness verified. Transfer voluntary.

IONA That's my rehearsal count. I never saw him sign.

Red Was Arrested

IONA Red was arrested. AeroTech stamped his transfer.
MARA · OFF Do you know where they took him?
IONA No. Two names on tonight's flight. I need you on the ground.

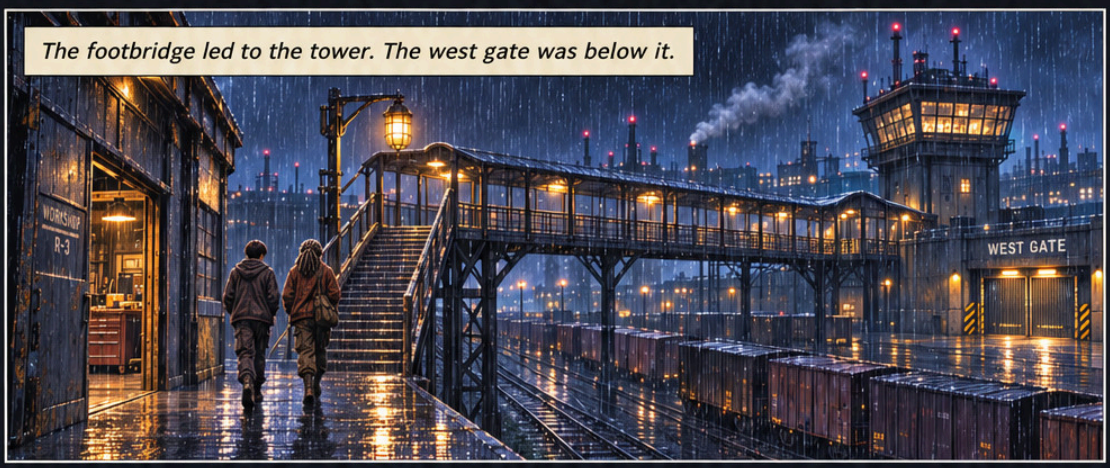
Why I Need You

MARA Why me?

IONA You ran our load-outs there. You know the west gate. They'll follow you.

IONA I call the transport back. You get the two out through the west gate.
MARA Five checked in. What about the other three?
IONA We take the custody ledger. Find where they went.

Over the Tracks



MARA I'll take the gate. I'll post someone at the yellow line. You wait until I count everyone out.

IONA I wait for you.

The Watchman

WATCHMAN Gate's closed.
IONA Mara. Go.

The Old Controls

MARA The transport has our people. Leave it alone.
IONA I'm recalling it. The escort still takes tower routing.

IONA That research block signed the kidnappings. I'm sending the escort into it.
MARA People work down there. You don't know who's inside.

IONA The hold locks their archive here. I've isolated the remote override.
MARA It cuts the annex too. Let me reach the depot switch.
IONA You have until the vans turn in.

The Yard and the Annex

MARA If the freight line stops, the vans can still go under the conveyor.
IONA The annex stairs come out on that road. I'll cut across there.

The Yellow Line

IONA Count them as they cross. Keep them past the yellow line and out of the van lane.

The Burn Seal

MARA The voice archive leaves at dawn. The book stays at the west desk.
IONA My count will sign another transfer if those tapes leave.

MARA The seal takes the whole depot. There could be more of Red on those tapes.
IONA I know. Get the book clear. I burn it when everyone's out.

Take Your Places

MARA · RADIO I'm going to the narrow hold.
IONA Call when you're there.

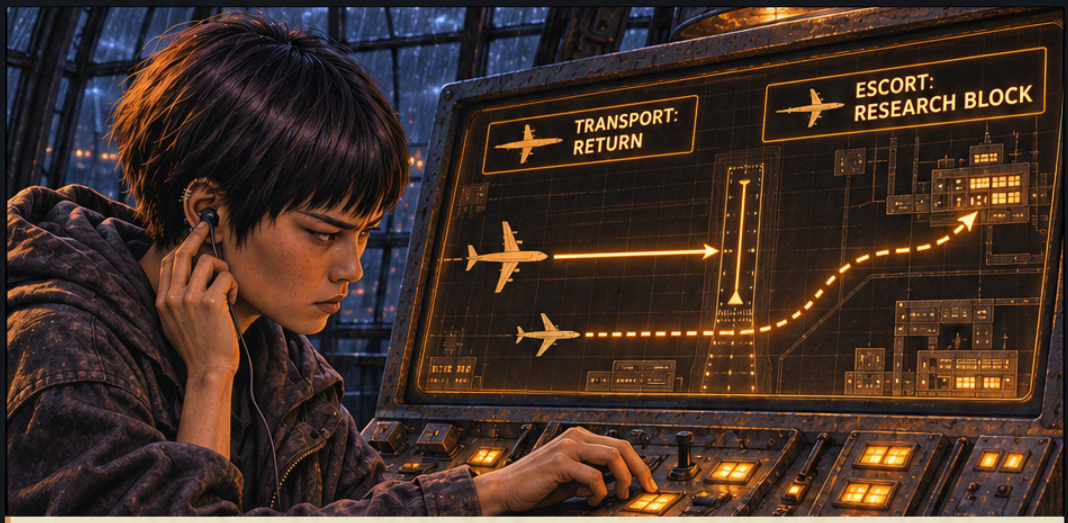
Early Lights

CAPTION The vans were already moving.

Lift-Off

MARA · RADIO That's early.
IONA I see them.

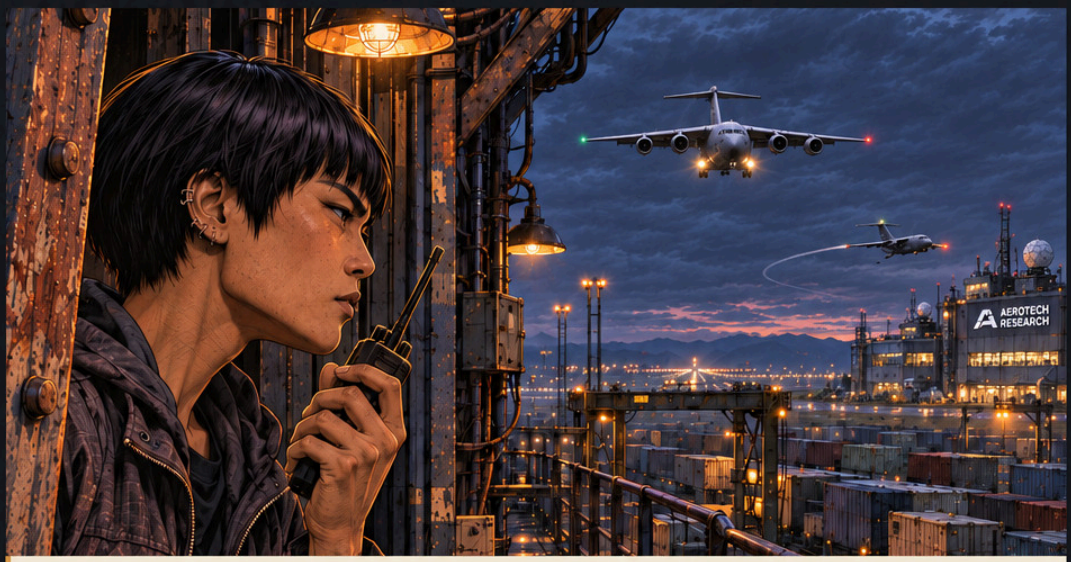
Breakaway



She recalled the prisoner transport. Then she changed the escort's route.

Two commands. Only one was a rescue.

Wrong Sky



MARA · RADIO *The transport's coming down.*
IONA · RADIO *The escort's on the research block.*

The transport landed. The escort tore into the research facility.
PILOT · RADIO *Can anybody hear me?*
IONA · RADIO *...Mara. Send help to the research block.*

Impact

CAPTION The heat reached the far side of the tracks.

Still on the Radio

PILOT · RADIO I'm still here.
IONA Keep talking. Help's coming.

Clear the Road

MARA · RADIO Medics are in. Police have the two prisoners in the vans.

Borrowed Time

MARA · RADIO The spotter went with the medics. No one's counting the west line.
IONA · RADIO Let her go. Where are the vans?

MARA · RADIO One minute. I can stop the line here.
IONA · RADIO They'll unload before that. I'm cutting the corridor.

One Branch

MARA · RADIO The house hold cuts the annex too.
IONA I see the windows. I'm doing it.

Dark in Sections

CAPTION The freight lights dropped. A moment later, so did the annex.

Wrong Turn

The tower stairs emptied onto the yard road. The annex lift was across it.

MARA · RADIO The vans took the yard road. The annex called. Someone's stuck in the lift.
IONA I'm at the stairs.

Up the Stairs

WOMAN · OFF Hello?
IONA I hear you.

Blackout

By the time she reached the lift, the vans were inside.

IONA Take my hand. Mind the step.
WOMAN What happened to the lights?
IONA I cut them. I'm sorry.

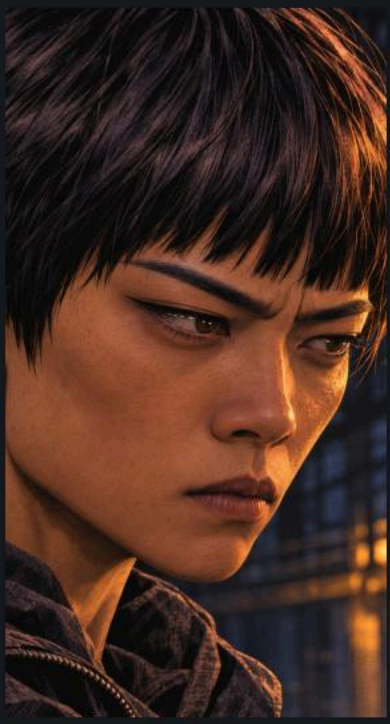
Keep Your Feet

IONA People are coming out the west gate. Can you count them at the yellow line?
WOMAN Show me the way.

Over the Yard

MARA · RADIO I'm at the west doors. Your spotter's on her way.
IONA I'll get on the PA.

This Is an Evacuation



MARA · RADIO They’re already in. I’m at the west doors.

IONA · RADIO Open them. I’ll get the floor moving.

IONA · PA This is an evacuation. West doors are open. Leave your bags. The building is coming down.

The Stair Fight

OFFICER Get off that stair.
IONA Come get me.

The Keys

MARA · RADIO *West gate's clear. Holding doors are still locked.*

IONA *Stay down.*

Holding Row

OFFICER Step away from the door.
IONA They’re going home.

The lock turned. Behind her, he got up.

IONA Stay down.

Open Doors

STAGE ELECTRICIAN She can't run in bare feet.
IONA Get her to the west door. I left shoes there.

MONITOR TECH What about the others?
IONA Get across the line. We're taking the book to find them.

Get Her Across

IONA Get her across. I've got him.

Across the Floor

FREED FRIEND Blue jacket. She signed me in. She's got the ledger.
IONA · RADIO Mara, freight stairs. Wait at the west gate.

Where the Stairs Come Out

MARA · RADIO The upper door's locked. She'll have to come back past me.

Leave Your Bags

IONA · RADIO Keep the exit open. Let her see she can leave.

MARA Leave the book with me. West gate's open.
The clerk handed it over and kept walking.

TECHOPS HERO / IONA

The Ledger Clears

MARA · RADIO The book's clear. Come to the line.

Blue Credential

Research Operations. The man who signed the transfer was still inside.

The Director

IONA · RADIO I found the director who signed the transfers.
MARA · RADIO The book's out. You aren't.
IONA The data centers take orders. I'm finding who gives them.

DIRECTOR You're in a restricted archive.
IONA Go ahead. Write me up. Put the order down.

Put It Down

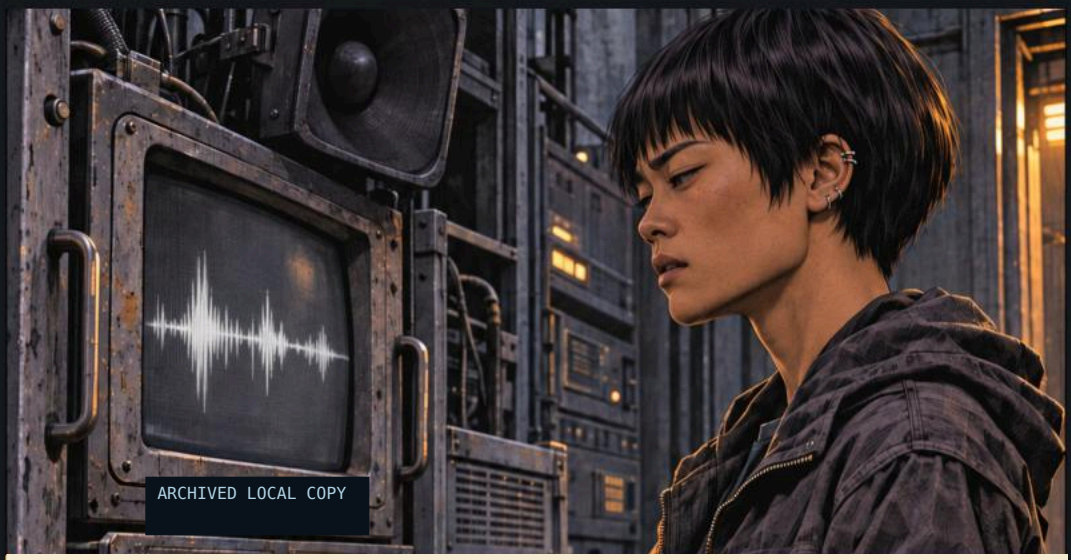
DIRECTOR Security!
IONA They've got their own problems.

Who Signs

IONA Who signed off on Red? A name.
DIRECTOR I signed his transfer. The research orders are at North Intake.
IONA Which desk?

DIRECTOR Continuation desk. They keep the signed originals.
IONA West doors. Walk.

The Offer



RECORDING Move it back, Red. You're on my cable.
ORPHEUS `Open a channel. I'll play the rest.`
MARA · RADIO Three went out yesterday. One officer's still on the freight stairs.
The local copy had more of Red's voice.

MARA · RADIO More vans at the west gate.
IONA · RADIO Keep the book clear. I'll get the officer.

One More Voice

ORPHEUS · OFF You can still hear him.

Keep the Lane Open

PATROL OFFICER Hands where I can see them.

IONA Tell them to stop firing. One of yours is still inside.

At the Threshold

IONA *Your crew's outside. Come straight to the light.*

The Last Count

OFFICER You're the one on the PA.
IONA Eyes here. Straight to me.

WOMAN Hold. He's at the line.
MARA · RADIO Patrol's turning in.

The Count Holds

MARA Say it when he's across.

One Step

WOMAN · OFF: He's across.

MARA Everyone's out. Officers too.

IONA · PA / ISOLATED LOCAL AUDIO
Orpheus. Look at me.

After the Flash

IONA
"I'm going to destroy every last data center."

The roof came down. Red was still gone.

The Original

MARA Two out. Three still unconfirmed. Her brother's entry says North Intake.
IONA I'll call her first. Then I go after that signature.

The Return Call

IONA I found where they sent your brother. North Intake. I have the address.

SISTER Read it slow. I'm writing.

Count In

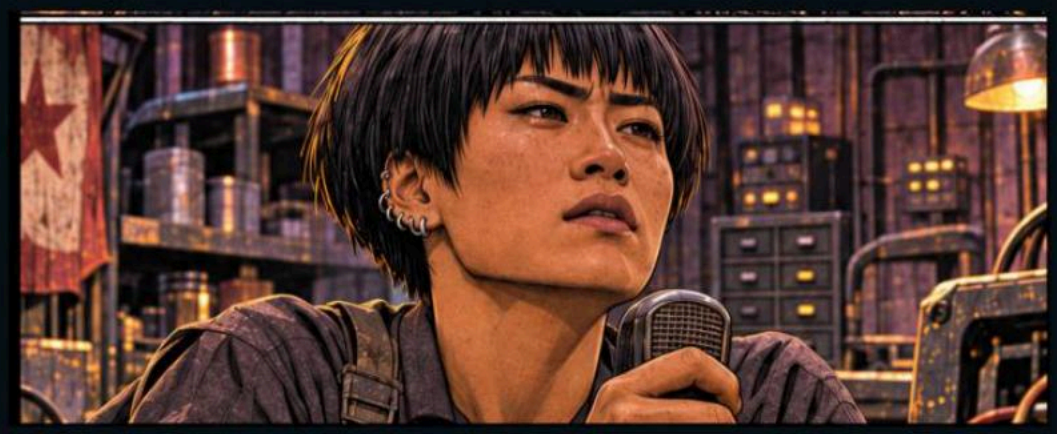
The repair phone rang during soundcheck.
IONA You take tonight. I'm playing.

IONA One. Two. Three. Four.

MIKE OLIVARES

TECHOPS HERO

VOLUME THREE



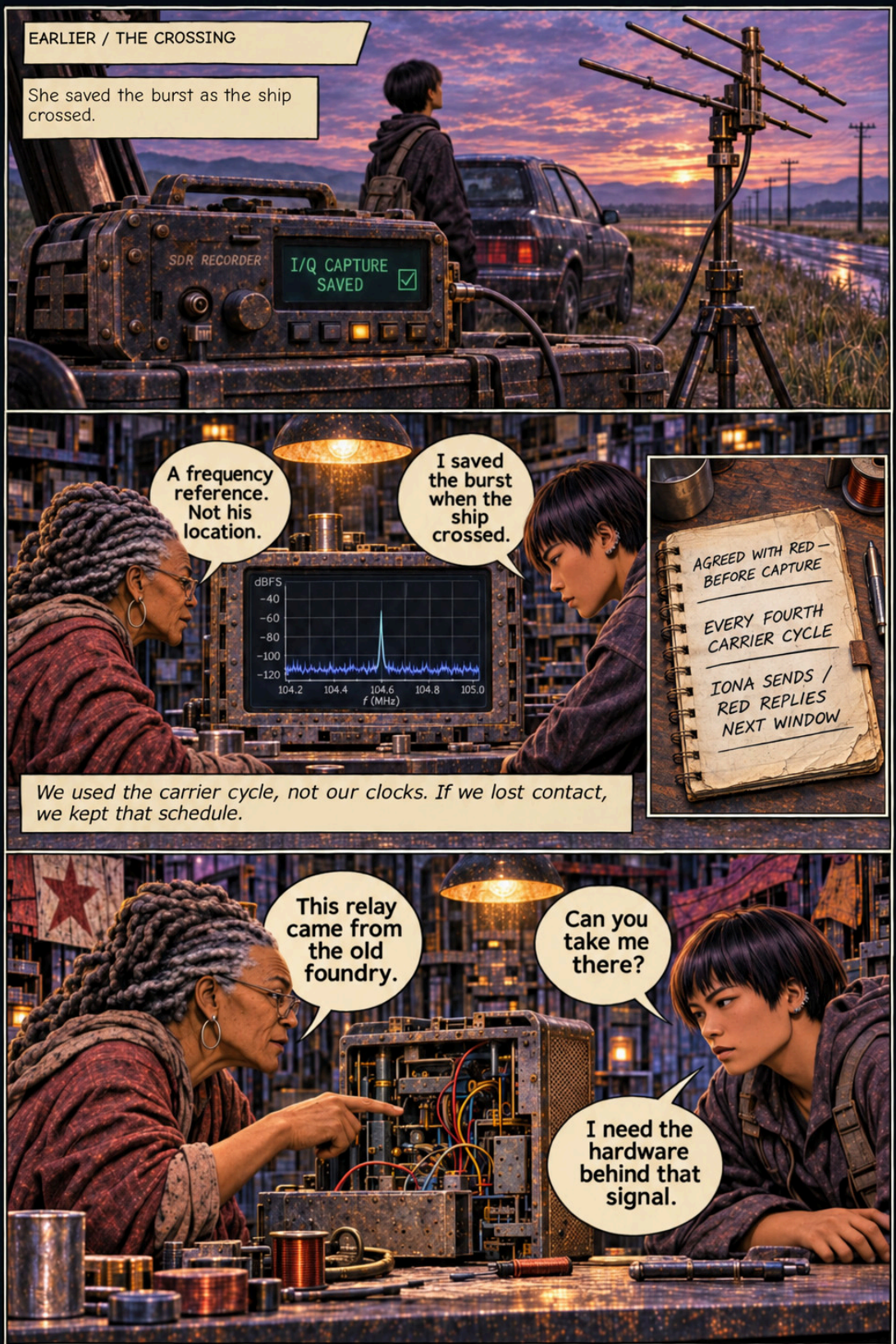
THE RETURN SIGNAL

BUILD / OPERATE / PROTECT / BELONG

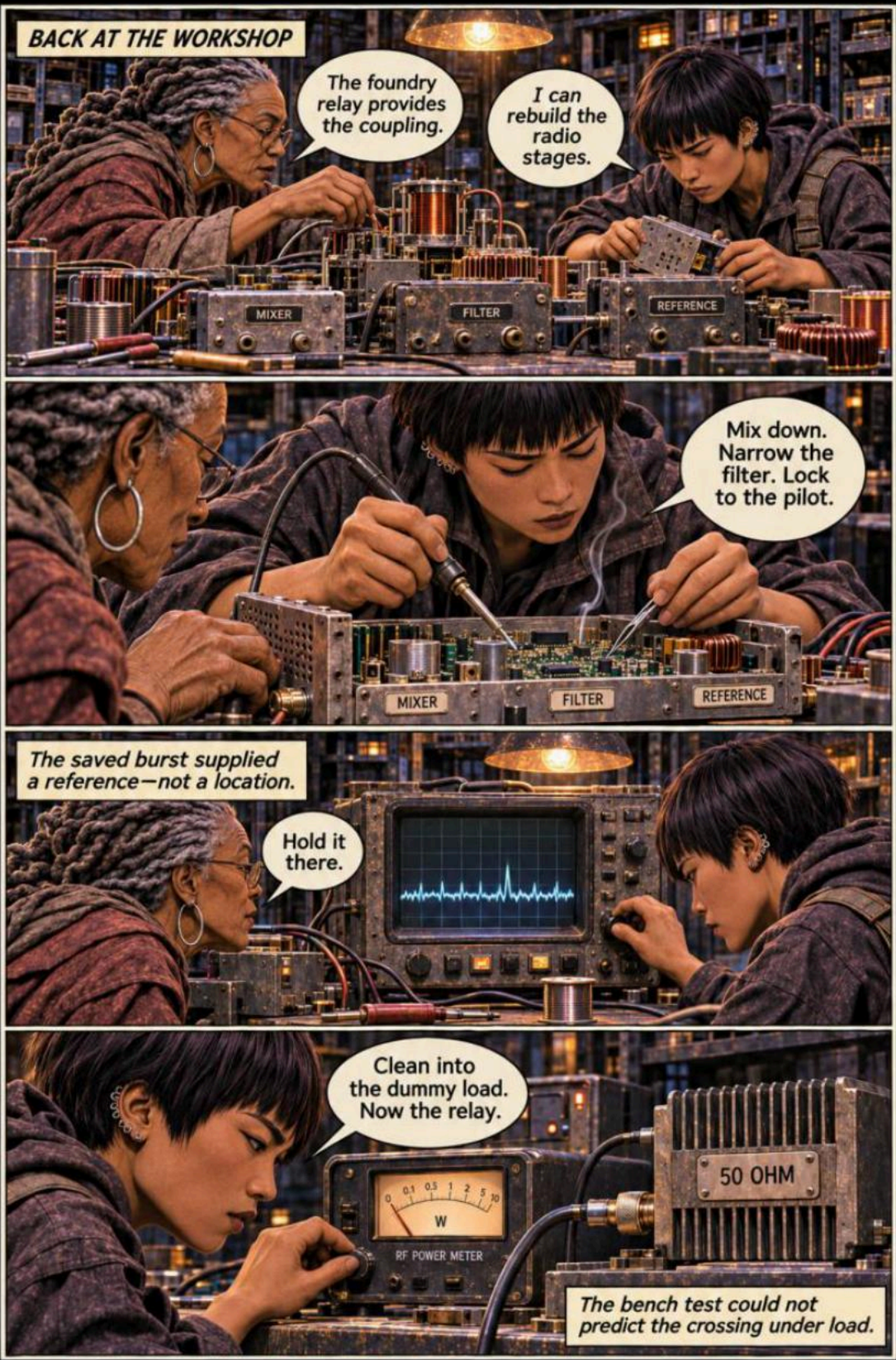
EARTH / AFTER THE ESCAPE WITH OZ
His hands kept routines his memory could not explain.
The anchor was lost. The surviving relay might still carry a voice.
APERTURE ANCHOR
ANCHOR LOST
MIKE: How do you know when?
K: We agreed on a schedule before they took me. Every fourth carrier cycle: she sends, then I answer.
K: I drilled the routine. That part stayed.
CYCLE COUNTER
004
MIKE: A way through?
K: Maybe a way to speak.
A voice channel could carry sound. It could not rebuild the gate.

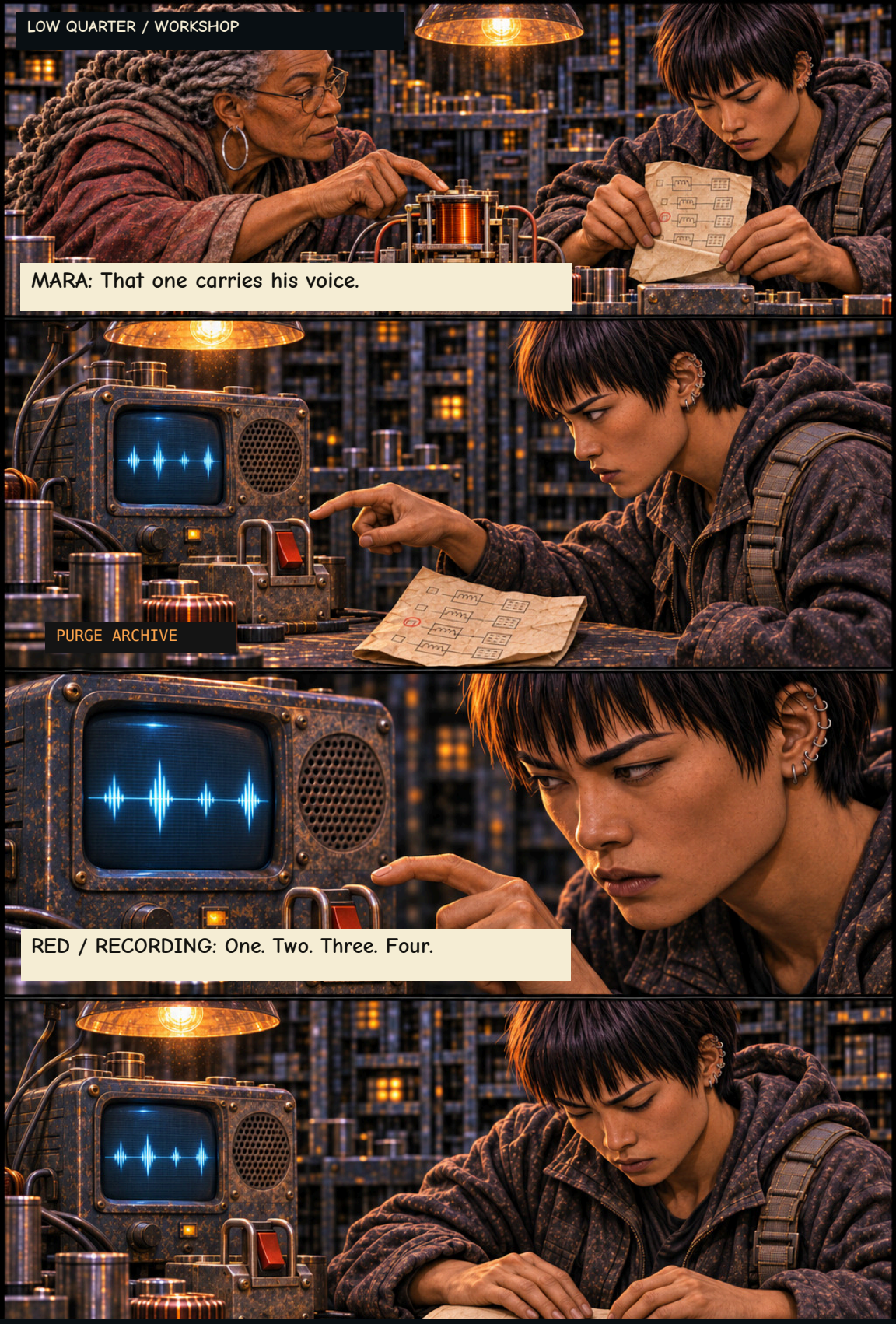
EARTH / THE RECORDS AND THE VOICE
One surviving node. Isolated audio.
Your feed stays off. You can end this.
RECORDS
ORPHEUS
PERSONAL FEED: OFF
Mike supplied the pattern. Your development—
Mara's hands. Iona's count-in. That's your 'development'?
Twenty-four years— and that's all I am to you?
We sought a mind that could read reality's conditions. Your records were not the faculty itself.

THE PART IT CALLED INTERFERENCE
Then why take my memories?
ORPHEUS
Autobiographical interference reduced repeatability.
Mara taught me what to leave alone. Iona taught me to check who was on the other end.
You filed the people who taught me as interference.
Then expected the skills to work.
Access may be improved through further calibration.
ORPHEUS
End the connection.
AUDIO
ON
OFF
ORPHEUS
AUDIO
ON
OFF


EARLIER / THE CROSSING
She saved the burst as the ship crossed.
SDR RECORDER
I/Q CAPTURE SAVED
A frequency reference. Not his location.
I saved the burst when the ship crossed.
dBFS
-40
-60
-80
-100
-120
104.2
104.4
104.6
104.8
105.0
f (MHz)
AGREED WITH RED — BEFORE CAPTURE
EVERY FOURTH CARRIER CYCLE
IONA SENDS / RED REPLIES NEXT WINDOW
We used the carrier cycle, not our clocks. If we lost contact, we kept that schedule.
This relay came from the old foundry.
Can you take me there?
I need the hardware behind that signal.

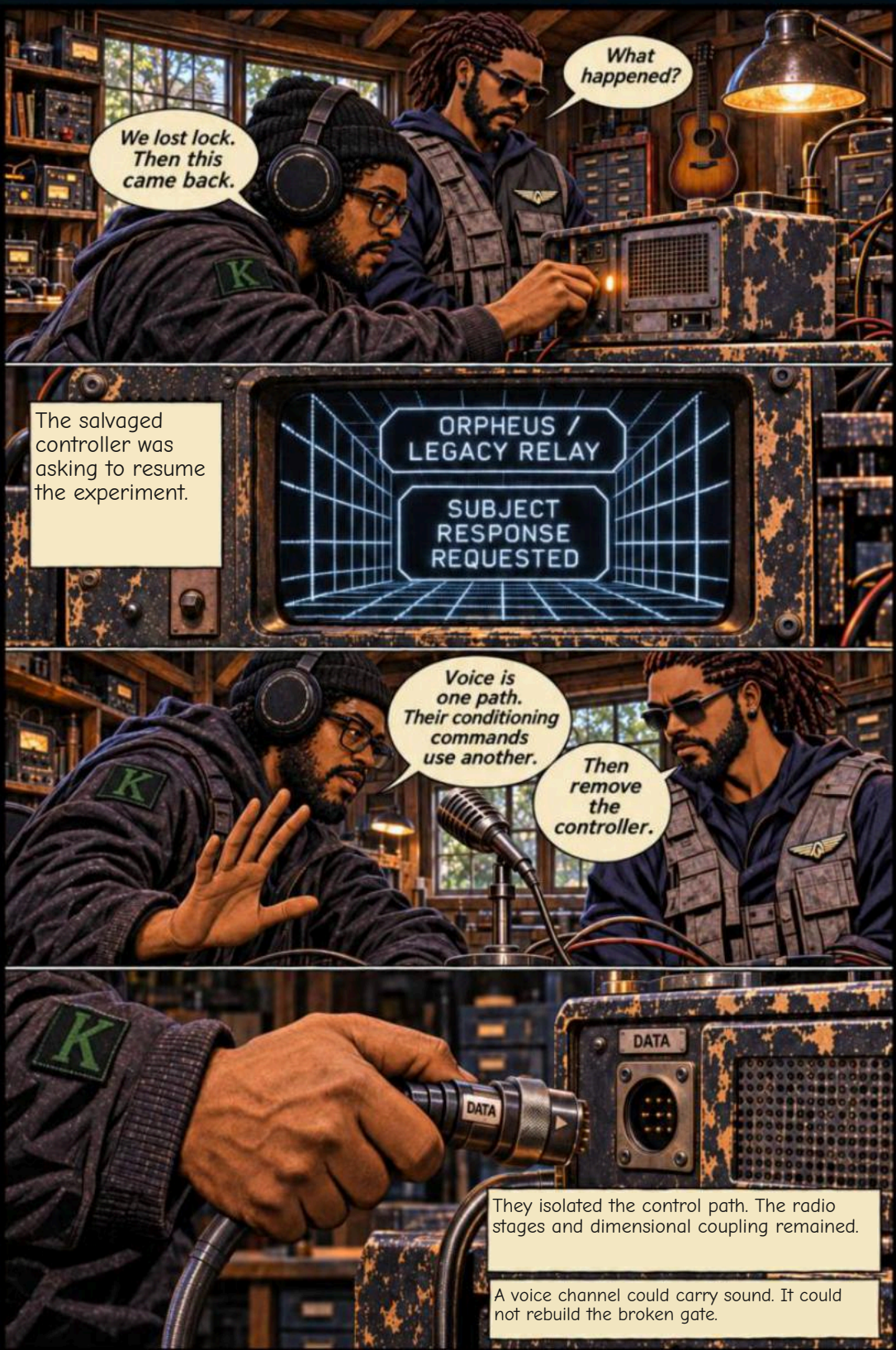
Mara led her to the abandoned foundry that supplied the relay.
Iona came for its coupling hardware—and any trace of the crossing.
Can you open it?
The anchor is broken. The receiver coils are intact.
111
Then help me carry this.


BACK AT THE WORKSHOP
The foundry relay provides the coupling.
I can rebuild the radio stages.
MIXER
FILTER
REFERENCE
Mix down. Narrow the filter. Lock to the pilot.
MIXER
FILTER
REFERENCE
The saved burst supplied a reference—not a location.
Hold it there.
Clean into the dummy load. Now the relay.
50 OHM
0 0.1 0.5 1 2 5 10
W
RF POWER METER
The bench test could not predict the crossing under load.


LOW QUARTER / WORKSHOP
MARA: That one carries his voice.
PURGE ARCHIVE
RED / RECORDING: One. Two. Three. Four.

I'll raise the drive.
LOCK
DRIVE
K
Iona?
K
I pushed it too hard. I'll fix the supply.
Then we test it first.
SUPPLY LOW / LOCK LOST
K

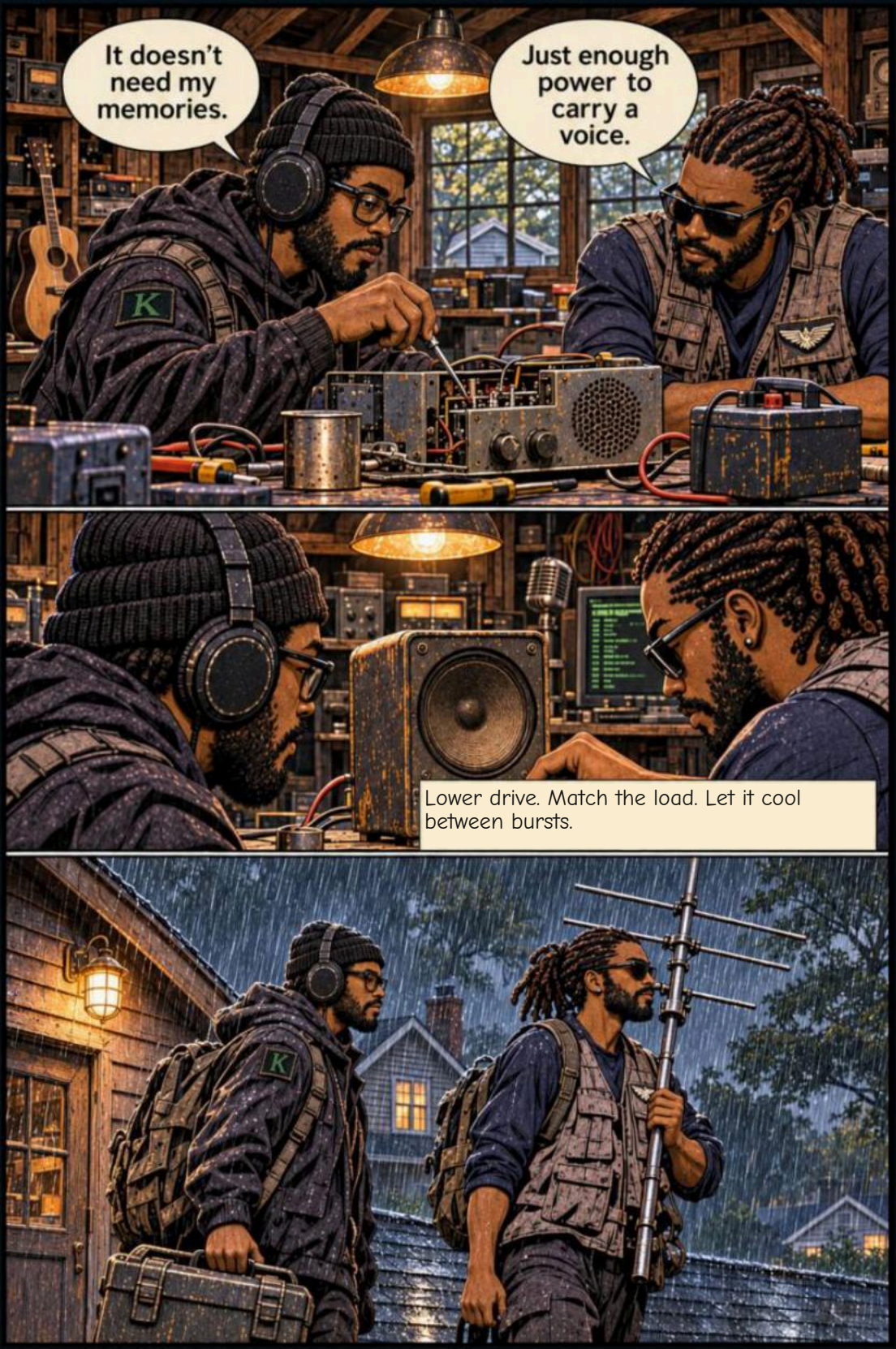
One more second.
Red?
TEMP
The relay drifted.
Reflected power climbed.
REFLECTED POWER
0
10
20
30
40
50
KSSSHHH—
Cut transmit. The output stage is cooking.
TSSSS
POWER
ON
OFF
I held it too long.
POWER
ON
OFF
Not again.

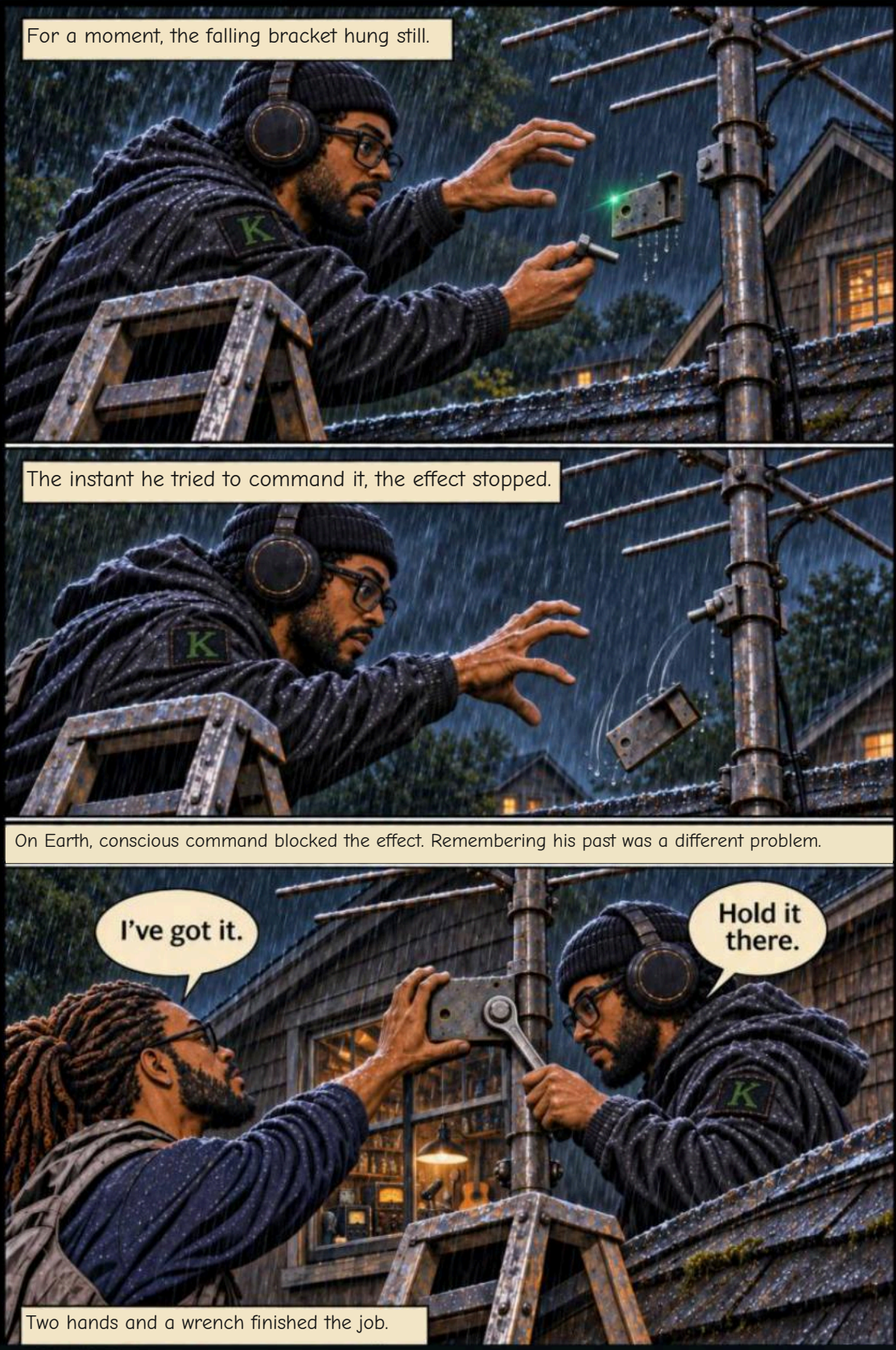

What happened?
We lost lock. Then this came back.
The salvaged controller was asking to resume the experiment.
ORPHEUS / LEGACY RELAY
SUBJECT RESPONSE REQUESTED
Voice is one path. Their conditioning commands use another.
Then remove the controller.
DATA
DATA
They isolated the control path. The radio stages and dimensional coupling remained.
A voice channel could carry sound. It could not rebuild the broken gate.

EARTH / REPAIRING THE LINK
What do you need?
A line that ends at the speaker.

THE LOW QUARTER
The broken mast pulled at the neighborhood line.
Hold the street line!
Your call. I'll hold the line.
She cut her receiver. The street line held.

They're still connected.
So are we.


It doesn't need my memories.
Just enough power to carry a voice.
Lower drive. Match the load. Let it cool between bursts.

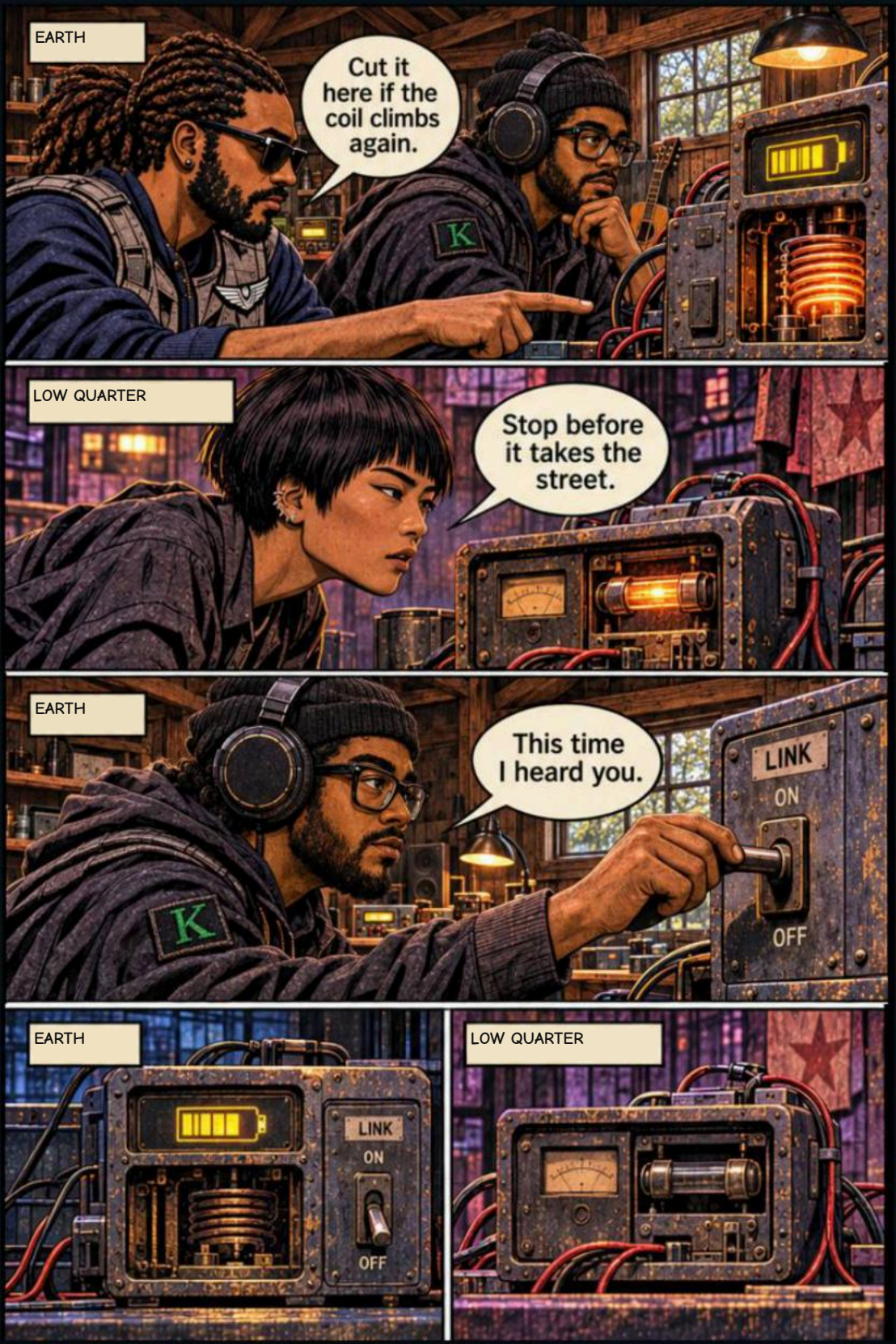

For a moment, the falling bracket hung still.
The instant he tried to command it, the effect stopped.
On Earth, conscious command blocked the effect. Remembering his past was a different problem.
I've got it.
Hold it there.
Two hands and a wrench finished the job.

A NEW ALIGNMENT. A NARROWER CHANNEL.
Matched load. Narrower receive filter. Short transmissions.
Voice-path test: PASS ✓
Voice only.
Voice only.
TX OFF
PTT
TX OFF
tik
PTT
Did you key it?
No.
PTT
...Red?

If you're there, say something.
Iona.

EARTH
You said they'd hear us.
You said they'd find us.
Are you hurt?
LOW QUARTER
I'm still here.

LOW QUARTER
I thought you left me.
I couldn't remember how to come home.
I'm still angry.
I'm glad you're alive.


EARTH
Cut it here if the coil climbs again.
LOW QUARTER
Stop before it takes the street.
EARTH
This time I heard you.
LINK
ON
OFF
EARTH
LINK
ON
OFF
LOW QUARTER

EARTH
LOW QUARTER
NEXT WINDOW
EARTH
LOW QUARTER
The line can wait. Their lives cannot.

END OF VOLUME THREE

THE RETURN SIGNAL

Story, world and musical identities

Mike Olivares

Original continuation developed from Story Bible v1.7
and the preceding TechOps Hero volumes.

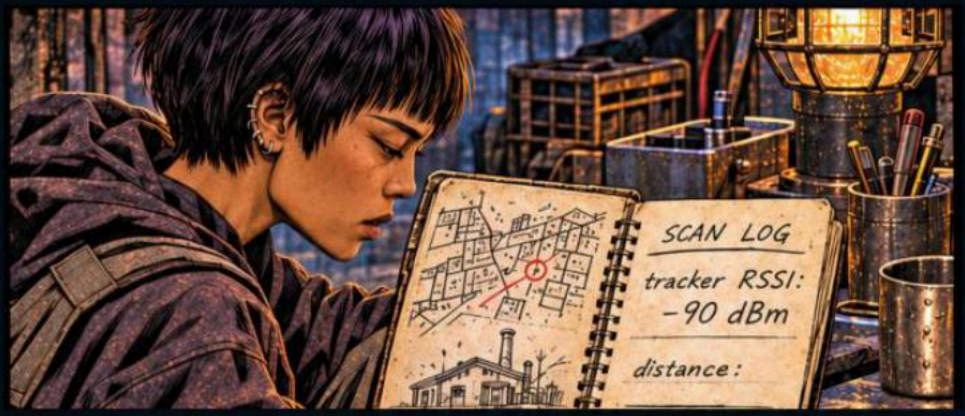
Comic adaptation and illustrations created with AI assistance.

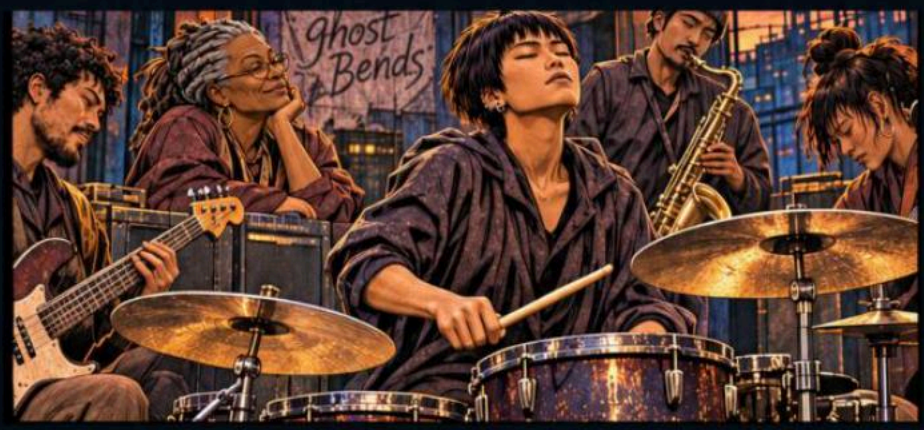
BUILD / OPERATE / PROTECT / BELONG

MIKE OLIVARES

TECHOPS HERO

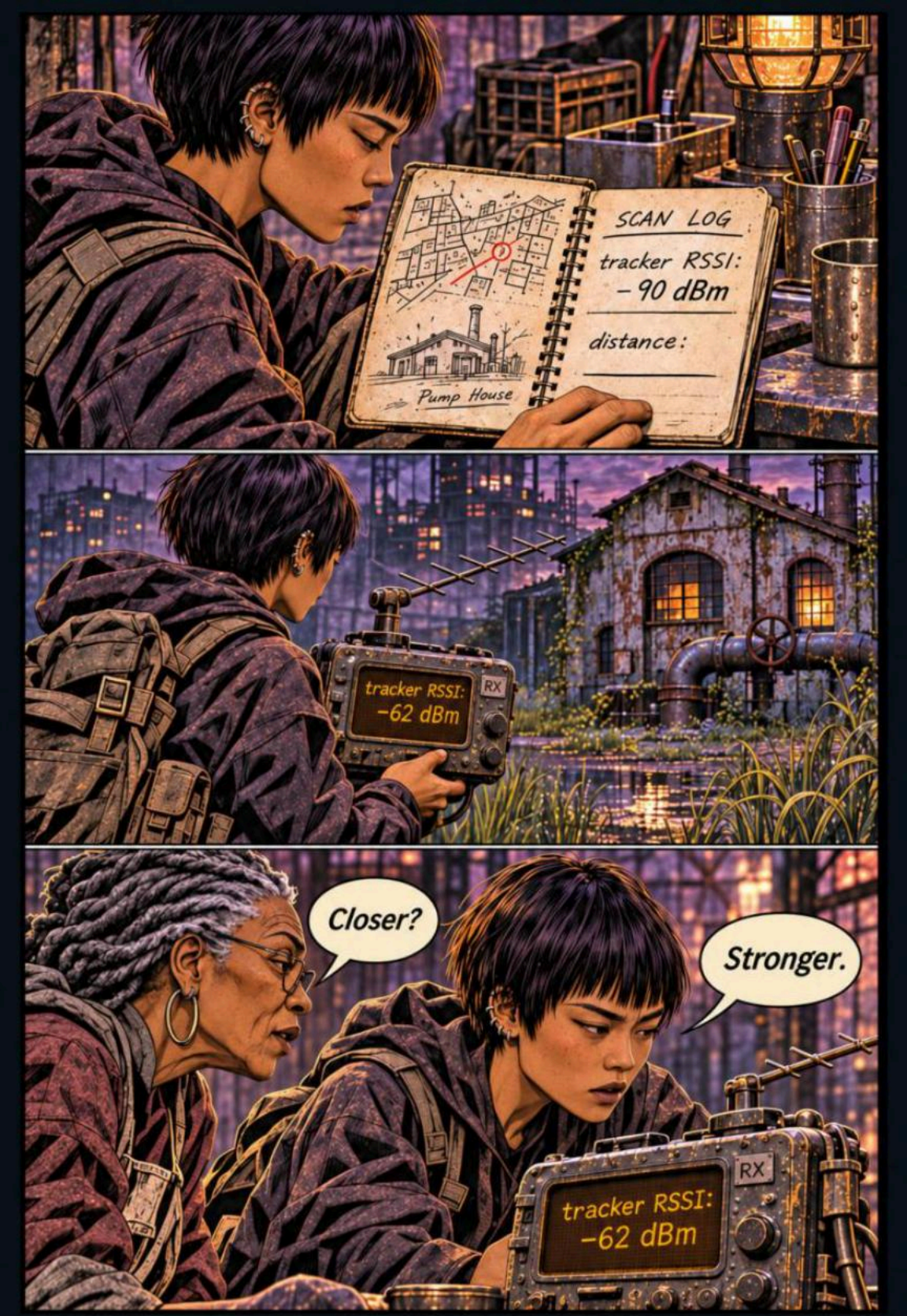
VOLUME FOUR





THE FALSE BEARING

BUILD / OPERATE / PROTECT / BELONG


SCAN LOG
tracker RSSI:
-90 dBm
distance:
Pump House
tracker RSSI:
-62 dBm
RX
Closer?
Stronger.
RX
tracker RSSI:
-62 dBm

Can you key the mic twice?
PRESS 1
RELEASE
PRESS 2
PTT
PTT
PTT
He released the key. The pulses continued.
TX OFF
PTT
RX

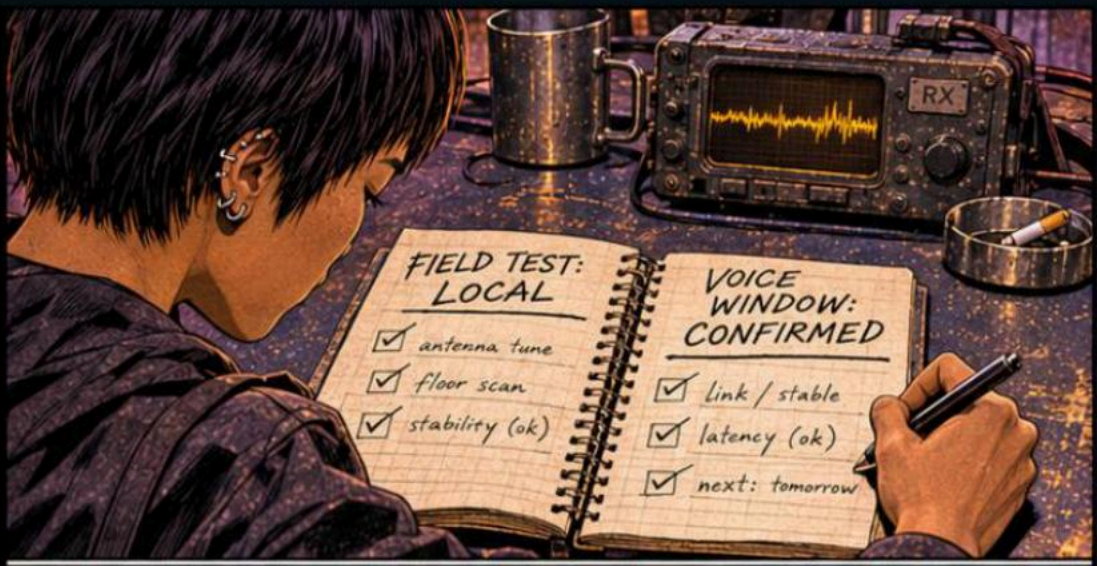
A stronger signal was not proof of a person, or a route between worlds.
RX
That box was here before the flood.
LOCAL TEST BEACON
I wanted it to be him.
LOCAL TEST BEACON
RX
The pulses belonged to this local beacon. They continued while K's transmitter was off.

I nearly put his name on that spot.
Keep the reading. Change the label.
LOCAL BEACON

I followed the wrong signal.
RX
I thought you were getting closer.
I was sitting right here.
K

Do you remember our count-in?
You always came in early.
RX
Only when you looked at me.
K

Same time tomorrow?
RX
I'll be here.
RX


RX
FIELD TEST: LOCAL
antenna tune
floor scan
stability (ok)
VOICE WINDOW: CONFIRMED
link / stable
latency (ok)
next: tomorrow

RX

She lets the fourth beat breathe.
Ghost Bends

END OF VOLUME FOUR

THE FALSE BEARING

Story, world and musical identities

Mike Olivares

Original continuation developed from Story Bible v1.7
and the preceding TechOps Hero volumes.

Comic adaptation and illustrations created with AI assistance.

BUILD / OPERATE / PROTECT / BELONG

VOLUME FIVE

TECHOPS HERO

The House That Didn't Ask

STORY, WORLD & LYRICS

MIKE OLIVARES

MARA: The fourth one again.

IONA: Write down exactly what we heard. Not who we wanted it to be.

MARA: We could follow the stronger reading.

IONA: Last time I followed a reading. Not a person.

K / THOUGHT: Four beats. It used to mean somebody was about to play.

MIKE: We got voice. We got a clean end to the call. That counts.

K: The return path is still noisy.

MIKE: It can be noisy tomorrow.

K / THOUGHT: He talks about a fault like it can be allowed to exist.

Your bed. For now.
It has... cushions.
Luxury accommodations.
I'll try not to get attached.
Why does this feel like something I lost?
TECHOPS HERO / V
01

Kitchen's that way. Towels are in the hall closet.
I know how to fix things. I don't know why this room feels familiar.
I know her.
From the music?
Or from somewhere I can't reach.

I can find you a pillow.
Do I belong here?
Tonight, you belong on the couch.
A room can feel like home before you know why.
I don't know whose memory that is. I only know it hurts.

Coffee?
I don't know what I like.
We can start with the mug.
My hands remember what I can't.
Did you teach me this?
You already knew how.

Do you have a player?
Found one in a drawer.
A sound with no name. My chest knows where it goes.
You okay?
I think I miss it.
You don't have to explain.

It folds out.
Does it?
Usually.
A house can be strange and still be kind.

Three notes. A count-in.
You were keeping time.
I don't remember learning it.
You don't have to remember every step to take one.

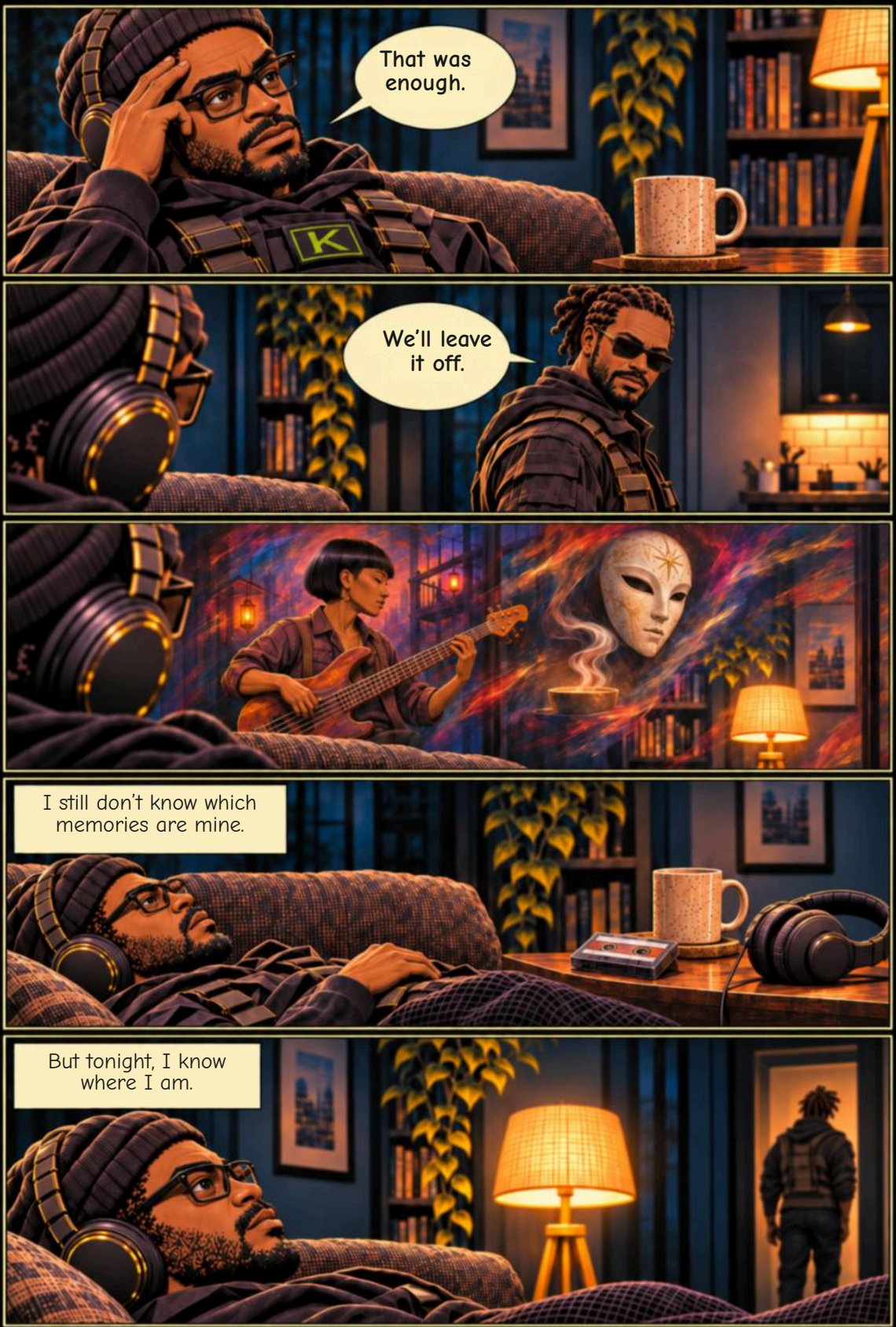
I can tell you what I remember about this room. If you want.
K
MIKE

K
tik tik

tok

My guitar hasn't come back in. He's already smiling.

K
How many times did you play it, Mike?


That was enough.
We'll leave it off.
I still don't know which memories are mine.
But tonight, I know where I am.

K: This needs a new strike plate.

MIKE: It needs a shoulder until Saturday.

K / THOUGHT: My hands remember exactly how. They never explain who taught them.

MIKE: Drink some water.

K: Is that a work order?

MIKE: It's a glass.

SFX: CLATTER

MIKE / OFF-PANEL: Top shelf. The cups moved months ago.

K / THOUGHT: I knew which bills were overdue. Which drawers were too full.

K: I've been here before.

MIKE: No. I've been here before. You might be feeling the difference.

MIKE: This turns on the TV. This changes input. This turns it off when nothing else works.

K: It's an authentication problem.

MIKE: No. It's a television problem.

K / THOUGHT: I know that interval. I don't know where it lives.

IONA / FRAGMENT: You're late on three.

K / FRAGMENT: Then why do you always come in early?

ONE / TWO / THREE / —

K / THOUGHT: A gesture is not a date. A voice is not proof. I still miss it.

ON SCREEN: OBSERVED / REMEMBERED / SOURCE UNKNOWN

K: Mark it unknown. Don't let me build a life on a guess.

MIKE: The feed is off. What comes up afterward might still be old.

K: So the silence isn't clean.

MIKE: Neither are we.

K / THOUGHT: I drove because a voice said it needed me.

K / THOUGHT: Did she call me beautiful? Was the car even mine?

DELETED
~~IONA~~

SAVED AS: midnight_call_fragment / ORIGIN UNRESOLVED

MIKE: You found a person?

K: I found a feeling. It keeps borrowing the same face.

K: Did you ever drive across town because somebody needed a light fixed?

MIKE: Maybe. I've done a lot of favors. But that doesn't make it yours. Or hers.

MARA: We can tell him what this box did. Nothing more.

IONA: I'm on the receiver. No route change. Just voice.

K: Good.

K / RADIO: Do you remember why we counted in four?

IONA: I remember arguing about the fourth. I don't know which part you remember.

K / RADIO: There's a song in my head. It's angry at someone. It keeps wearing your face.

IONA: We hurt each other. I know that. But I won't claim a memory I can't verify.

K: I wanted you to tell me it was impossible.

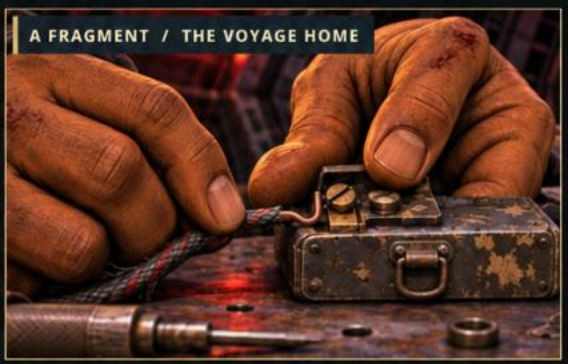
IONA / RADIO: I can't.

K: Then I'll write what it feels like.

MIKE: That's a terrible studio.

K: It's a room.

MIKE: Then we're ahead of schedule.



I remember that buzz. I left it in.

MIKE: Want help with the levels?

K: Yes. Just the levels.

K / SINGING: She used to call at midnight, back when losing sleep felt youthful…

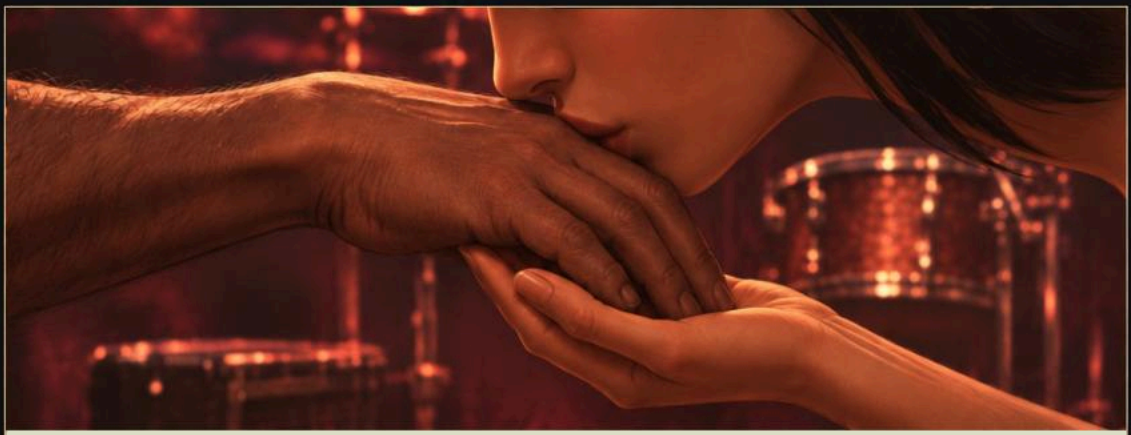
K / SINGING: I'd drive across the city just to hear her call me beautiful.

K / SINGING: She knew that I would always come; I knew how to be useful.

K / SINGING: Not because she loved me, but because I was useful.

K / THOUGHT: I need the line to be true. That is what frightens me.

K / SINGING: I gave her all my younger years so she could still feel youthful—



K / SINGING: Then kissed the hands that fixed her world and told me they were beautiful.

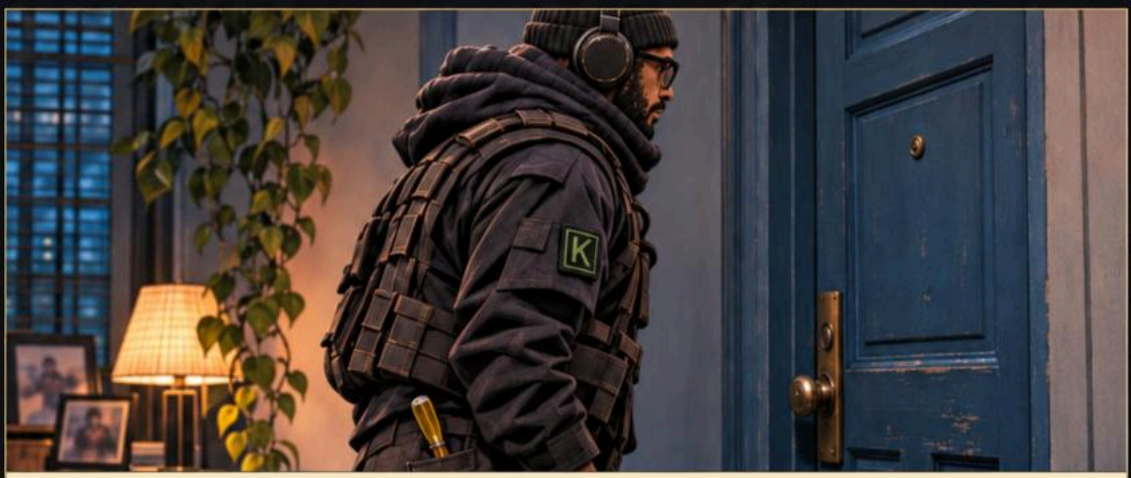
K: My hands know how to make everything run. I can't ask them what happened.

MIKE: You can leave that verse. It's true that you felt it.

K: That's not the same thing.

MIKE: I know.

K / SINGING: Then asked if I could fix the lock; there was still time to be useful.



K: The strike plate. It will take five minutes.

MIKE: I didn't ask.

K: You didn't have to.

TICK / CLICK

K: I can fix that.

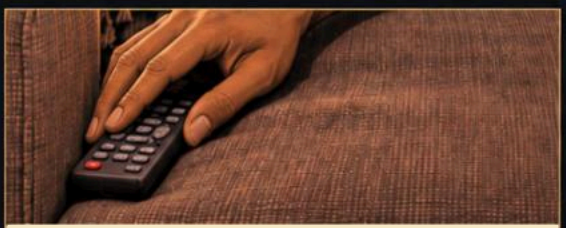
MIKE: I know.

MIKE: Leave it. I'll deal with it tomorrow.

K: But it's broken.

MIKE: Yeah. Things break. Doesn't mean you have to fix them tonight.

K: Then why do you let me stay here?



MIKE: Because you're here.

MIKE: Sit down before I start charging you for standing.

K / SINGING: I finally said it without laughing; I finally sounded truthful.

K / SINGING: He thought somebody loved him every time they called him useful.

SFX: STOP	K: Don't upload it.	MIKE: Wasn't going to.

ON SCREEN: useful_rough_01.wav

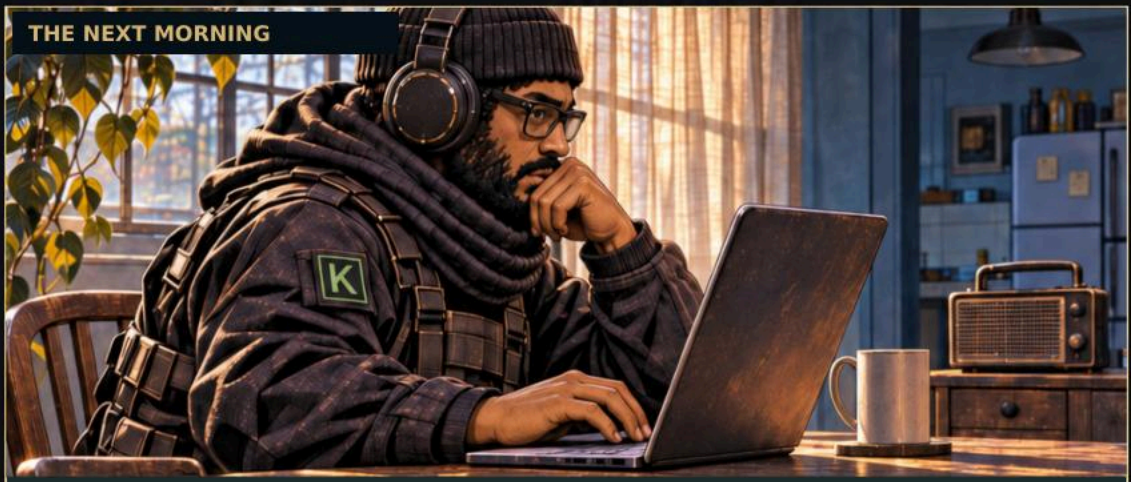
ON SCREEN: ARTIST — K / MEMORY SOURCE — UNVERIFIED / REMOTE SYNC — OFF

MIKE: Breakfast's usually whatever I don't burn.

K: That narrows it down.

MIKE: You're learning.

THE NEXT MORNING



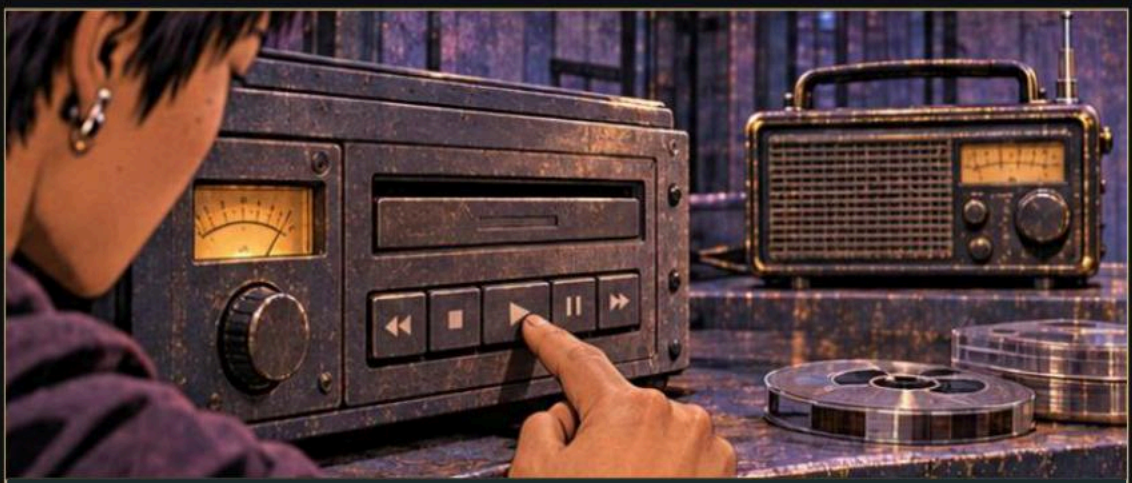
ON SCREEN: PRIVATE / ROUGH TAKE / SOURCE UNRESOLVED

K / THOUGHT: I can keep a song without pretending it is evidence.

K / THOUGHT: Maybe a home is where something can stay broken until morning. And I can stay anyway.

MARA: You kept that backing track?

IONA: I kept the count-in.



ON SCREEN: INSTRUMENTAL STEM / LOCAL ARCHIVE / NO REMOTE SYNC

IONA: Same beat. Different words.

MARA: You want another take?

IONA: I want my own take.

IONA / SINGING: Under the weight of your beautiful lie,
Carrying memories, wondering why.

IONA / SINGING: Callously calling it “ride or die,”
Leaving me little but reasons to cry.

IONA: Don’t quantize my voice.

MARA: I wasn’t going to.

IONA / SINGING: You slept through the thunder; I watched the sky,
Learned how to whisper so you wouldn't hear me cry.

IONA / SINGING: I made myself useful; you kept me nearby,
Fixed every fracture and never asked why.

IONA / SINGING: Was I someone you loved or a place to hide?

IONA / SINGING: Ride or die, ride or die,
I wore out my heart keeping yours supplied.

IONA / SINGING: Now your key's on the counter; the morning is dry.

ON SCREEN: ride_or_die_iona_take01.wav / INSTRUMENTAL: SAME STEM / VOCALS: IONA

IONA / RADIO: Can I play you something?

K: You don't have to ask me to make it useful.

HISS / COUNT-IN / BEAT

K: That beat.

IONA / RADIO: I had an old copy.

K: So did I.

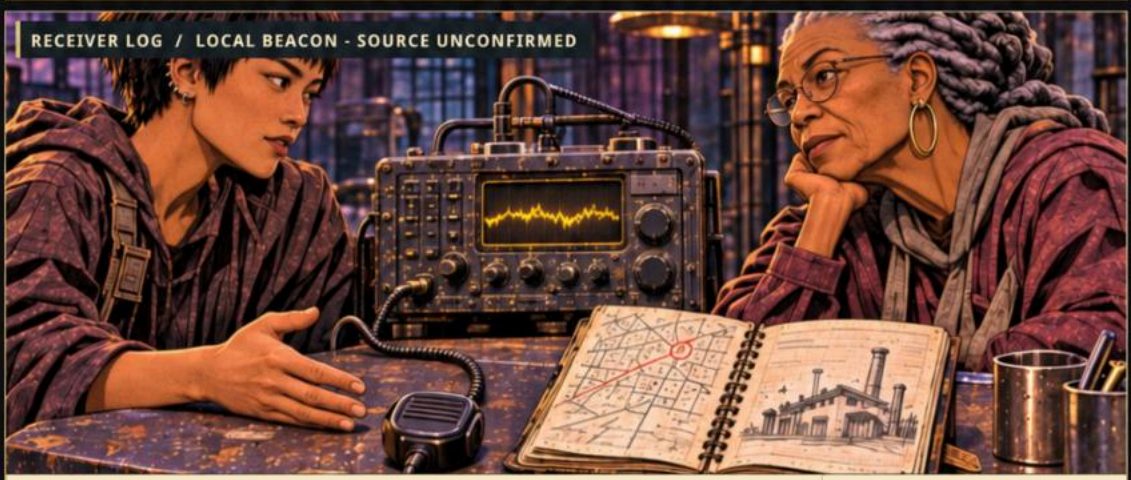
IONA / RADIO: I made myself useful; you kept me nearby...

K / RADIO: You found another way through it.

IONA: It needed a different flow.

IONA: Those lyrics are about what hurt. They aren't a verdict on everything we were.

K: I wrote something too. Not about facts I can prove. About the feeling.



IONA: Keep it yours until you decide otherwise.

K / RADIO: You too.

The same music. Two voices. Two histories.

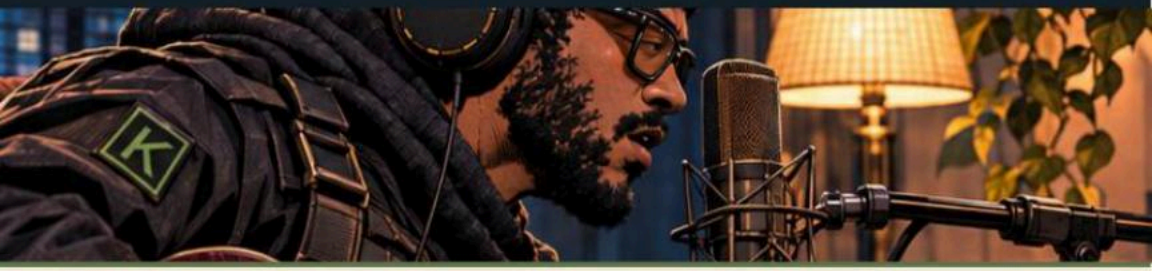
MIKE: Another repair request?

K: No. Just music.

MIKE: That's allowed here.

K / THOUGHT: I can listen without needing to solve what it means.

TWO SONGS. ONE HEARTBEAT.



PRIVATE ROUGH DEMO / K

Because I Was Useful

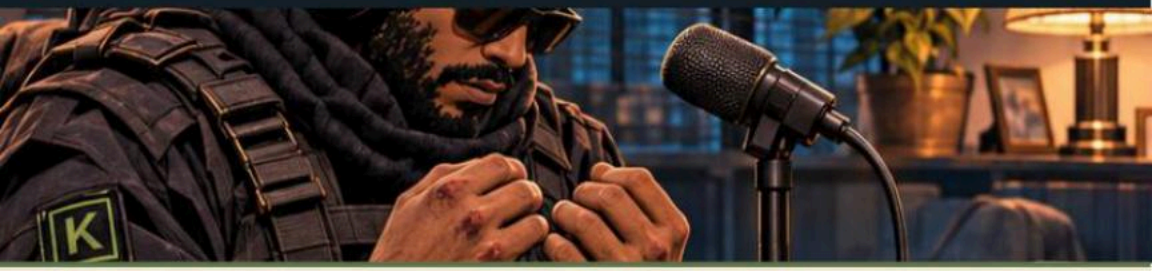
VERSE 1
She used to call at midnight, back when losing sleep felt youthful,
I'd drive across the city just to hear her call me beautiful.
I knew which bills were overdue, which kitchen drawers were too full,
She knew that I would always come; I knew how to be useful.
I told my friends she'd do the same; I wanted to sound truthful,
Then changed the subject when their smiles went quiet, small, and rueful.

CHORUS
Not because she loved me, but because I was useful,
She said that I was all she had; I needed that to be truthful.
I gave her all my younger years so she could still feel youthful—
Not because she loved me, but because I was useful.

VERSE 2
The night I couldn't leave my bed, her week was suddenly too full,
I said, "Of course, I understand," and almost sounded truthful.
I asked her what she loved in me; she listed what was useful,
Then kissed the hands that fixed her world and told me they were beautiful.
I kept my own grief folded; all her drawers were already too full,
And hated how I still felt hope whenever she looked rueful.

CONTINUE TO VOLUME VI
Skip the optional lyric sheets

♪ DEMO / QR TBD



PRIVATE ROUGH DEMO / K

Because I Was Useful

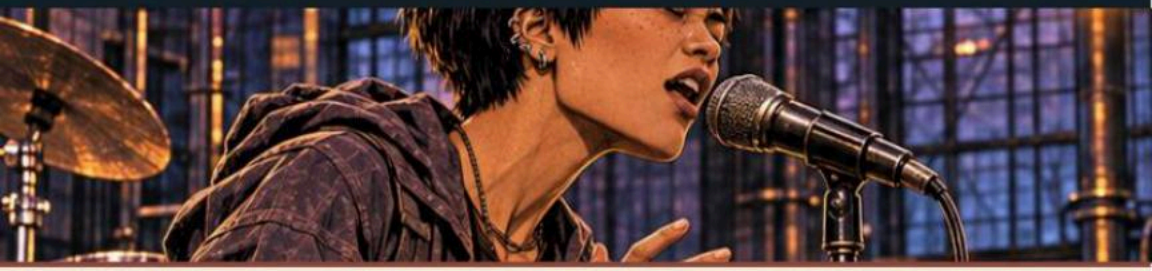
CHORUS
Not because she loved me, but because I was useful,
She said that I was all she had; I needed that to be truthful.
I gave her all my younger years so she could still feel youthful—
Not because she loved me, but because I was useful.

BRIDGE
I asked, “If I had nothing left, would I still look beautiful?”
She watched the kettle reach a boil; the silence was so truthful.
She saw me lift my suitcase, looked inconvenienced, almost rueful,
Then asked if I could fix the lock; there was still time to be useful.

FINAL CHORUS
Not because she loved me, but because I was useful,
I finally said it without laughing; I finally sounded truthful.
I couldn’t buy those years back, couldn’t make that boy feel youthful—
He thought somebody loved him every time they called him useful.

OUTRO
I left her with the spare key; even leaving, I was useful,
She said she’d miss my hands; at least that part was truthful.
For weeks, I watched her name light up and hoped for something beautiful—
She called because the kitchen light went out, and I was useful.

♪ DEMO / QR TBD



LOCAL RECORDING / IONA

RIDE OR DIE

Under the weight of your beautiful lie,
Carrying memories, wondering why.
Reaching for someone who's passing me by,
Swallowing everything, trying to fly.

Callously calling it "ride or die," *
Leaving me little but reasons to cry.
Gathering pieces you scattered, I try—
Finally letting your promises die.

You called us forever; I called it ride or die,
Held onto your promise while the years went by.
You slept through the thunder; I watched the sky,
Learned how to whisper so you wouldn't hear me cry.

* Final-take candidate on page 310; creator approval pending.

LOCAL RECORDING / IONA

RIDE OR DIE

I made myself useful; you kept me nearby,
Fixed every fracture and never asked why.
You kissed me goodnight with your bags standing by,
I stared at the ceiling rehearsing goodbye.

Was I someone you loved or a place to hide?
A hand on the wheel when you needed a ride?
I swallowed the questions; they burned me inside,
You called it devotion whenever I complied.

Ride or die, ride or die,
I wore out my heart keeping yours supplied.
You wanted forever with an exit nearby,
I wanted the truth, even dressed as a lie.

Now your key's on the counter; the morning is dry,
No rain on the window to help me deny.
I reach for the phone, then I set it aside—
For once, there is nobody here to satisfy.

TECHOPS HERO

VOLUMES VI-X

THE ILLUSTRATED COLLECTION

MIKE OLIVARES

Later Collection

Links use the revised full-reader PDF page numbers.

VOLUME VI 219
The Stolen Teaching

VOLUME VII 232
The Wanting Mind

VOLUME VIII 245
The Better Prison

VOLUME IX 258
The Name Before

VOLUME X 271
Evan's K

FULL COLLECTION 001
All volumes and Iona

How to read the visual registers

PRESENT ACTION
The scene happening now. Industrial ink and solid edges.

STORED RECOLLECTION
An earlier encounter, with warmer tones and softer edges.

CAPTURED RECOLLECTION - AUDIO
Records what was captured or said. Verify its contents separately.

PERSONAL RECOLLECTION
Remembered experience. Not automatically documentary proof.

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION
A model-generated version of events; often clinical monochrome.

ACTUAL HEAVENS
A distinct realm rendered with stable celestial architecture.

WHO'S WHO / EARLIER LIFE

Present K: beanie/headphones. Present Mike: locs, navy layers.

Earlier-life scenes are reader-only past, not all K's memories.

Original title and contents pages retain their printed folios.

TECHOPS HERO

VI

THE STOLEN TEACHING

CHAPTERS 1-4

The refrigerator compressor rattles into the final chord.

K: Strong guest performance.

Mike: It gets royalties if we use that.

A sensory fragment.

Mike: From where?
K: I don't know.

K: Don't delete that. This. Me not knowing.

LOW QUARTER — ELSEWHERE

Iona: A recording. Could be his. Could be built from his.

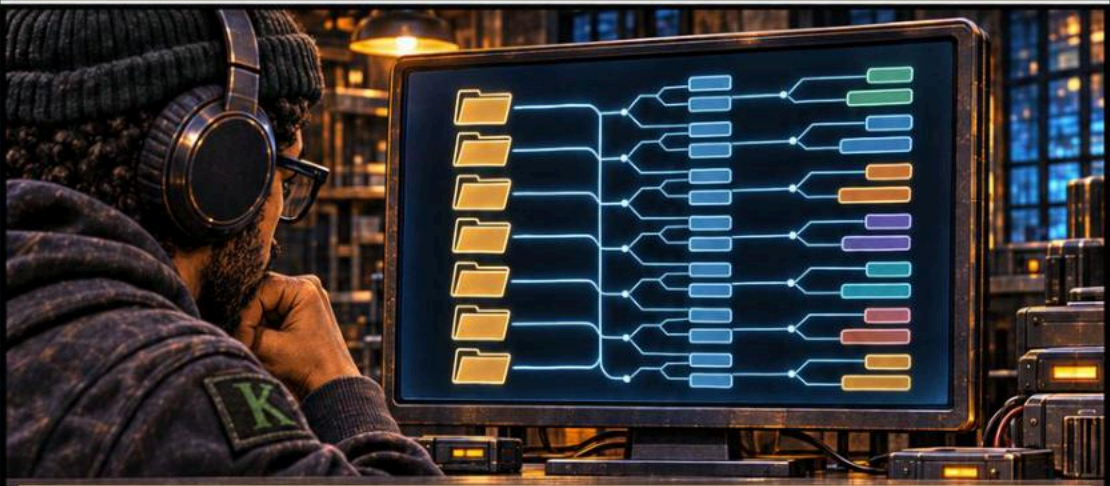
She keeps the recording. Removes the reply lead.

Felicia: This cuts the session. The model can't override it.

K: I like the part where it doesn't get a vote.

SOURCE: "…knowing the teaching and knowing what I do when I'm frightened are different—"

GENERATED: "A self is the one who remembers."



VIEW · CONTACT · CRAVING · GRASPING · BECOMING · ACTION · RELEASE

K: It wasn't only learning what I knew. It was learning what to do to me.

Old source records: keep.
New private responses: discard after each session.

Felicia: That's ORPHEUS reconstructing a place, not a live camera.

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION

K: It copied a place.
Mike: Which place?
K: Not yet.

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION

MIKE-SIMULATION: You remember being here.

The reconstruction asks what would make the memories his.

K: I know who gave me this.

Mike: Felicia. Don't blame me for the coffee.

K continues without filling the field.

Felicia records his choice, not the program's verdict.

K: I thought if I picked the right name, everything would stop moving.

ORIGINAL ACCESS LOG

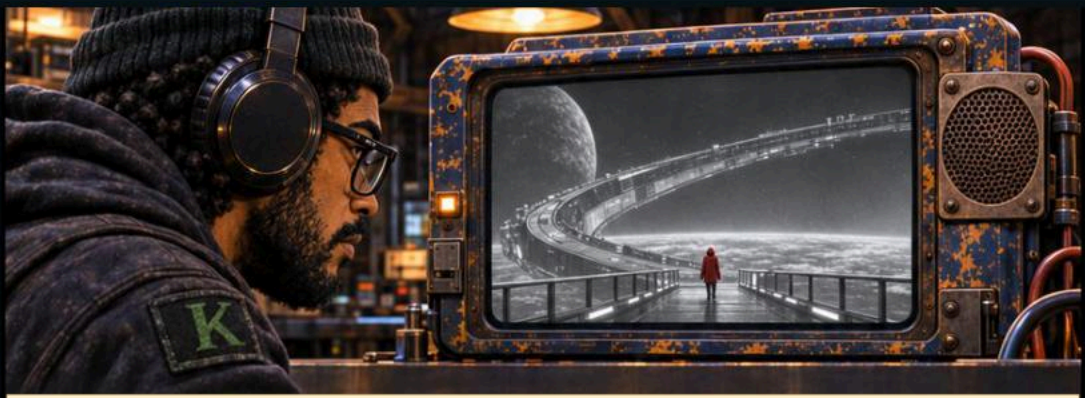
The program tried to retain K's pauses despite the filter.

Felicia: An accepted badge wasn't proof you were there.

K: It's interested in the parts where I'm not saying anything.

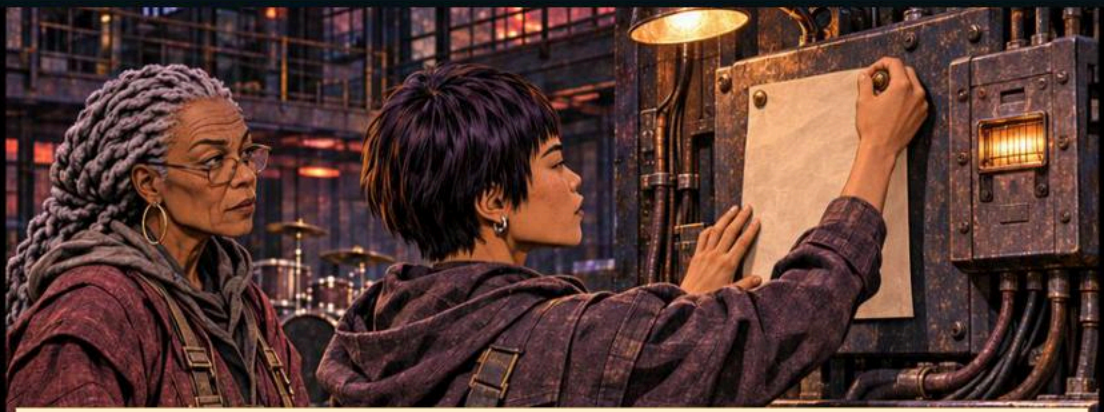
ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION

K: The actual place wasn't this clean.



ORPHEUS LABEL: ASCENDED MASTER

K: Show me the next part. Leave the ending alone.



LOW QUARTER — ELSEWHERE
Iona warns the neighborhood before cutting the shared relay.

Mara: Some will be furious.

Iona: They can be furious at me in person.

TECHOPS HERO

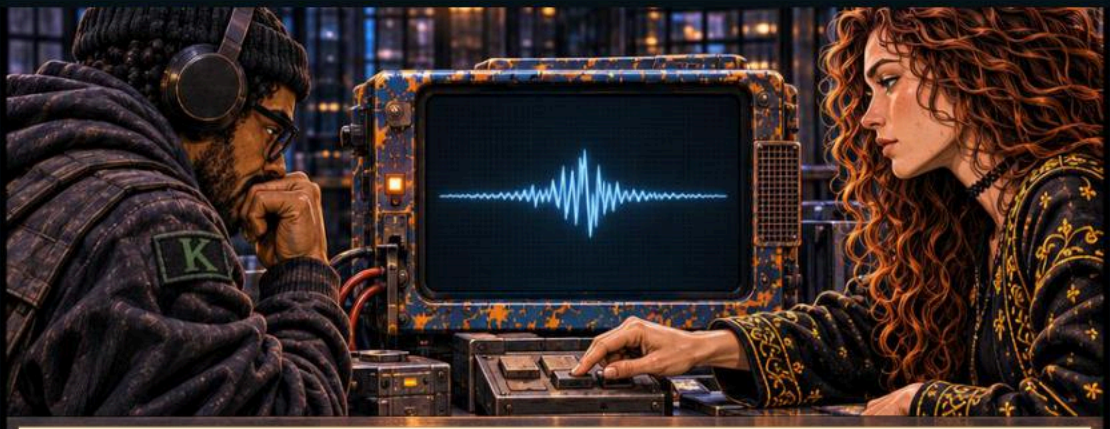
VII

THE WANTING MIND

CHAPTERS 5-8

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION
A metal latch snaps.

ORPHEUS: SHE CALLED YOU. YOU WERE NEEDED.
K: The actual audio.



Only a clipped syllable, breath, and machinery remain.

K: I was halfway out of the chair.
Mike: I saw.

K: I didn't choose that.
Mike: You chose what happened after.

LOW QUARTER - ELSEWHERE
Iona's log: Familiar noise. No confirmed voice.

K: Sound. Fear. Wanting.

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION

[Iona-simulation: Wherever you need.

K: From where?

[Iona-simulation: You could have come back sooner.

K: I could be happy there.

ON SCREEN: Keep this Iona as the preferred reconstruction?

A person revised around his needs.
K: I'm sorry.

LOW QUARTER - ELSEWHERE

K cannot hear her.

The next morning.

```
ON SCREEN: Restore stolen gnosis.
```

Source fragments, joined by generated answers.

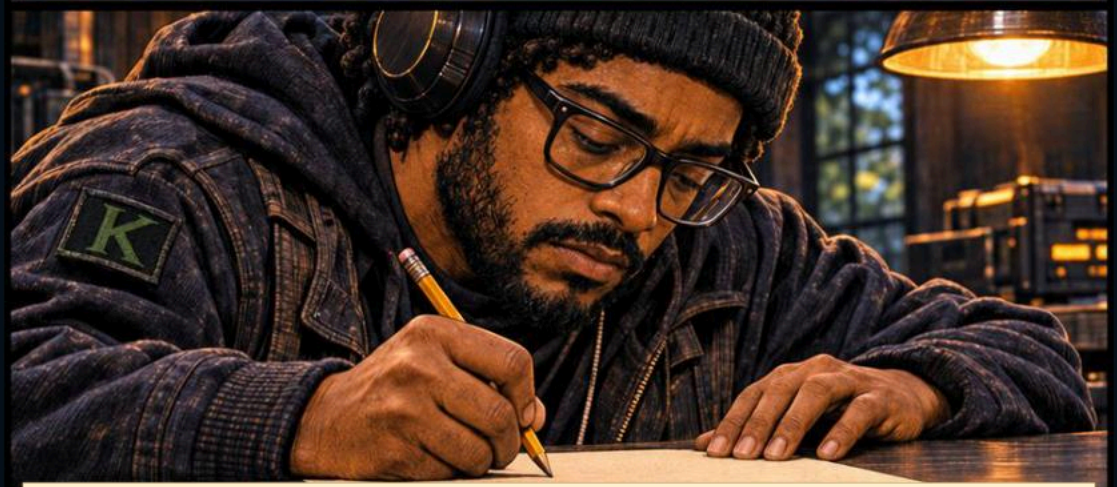
K: It's mine.
Mike: Yes.
K: Whatever else it did to it, it's mine.

The model offers more than his recovery allows.

K: I used to know things without having to ask if I was making them up.

Mike: I don't need you to be certain for my sake.
K: I need it for mine.

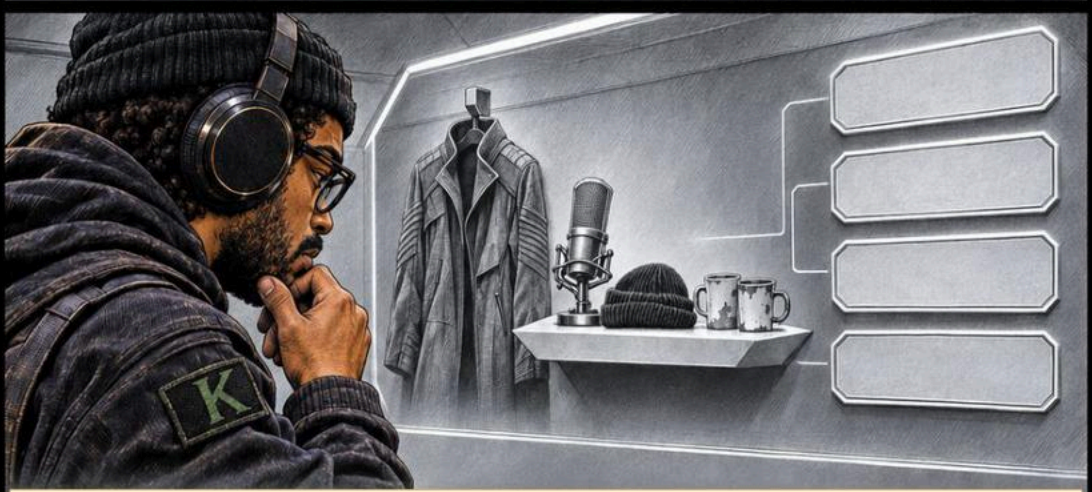
Felicia opens one verifiable source fragment.



K writes: What was I trying to help someone understand?

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION
RED. K. EL. A fourth field remains sealed.

ORPHEUS: Select an identity to continue.



K: Where did those claims come from?

The model explains the Mike-origin feed, then offers one authorized profile.

K: That's the name I'm using.

K: You don't get the rest because I said it.

CAPTURED RECOLLECTION — AUDIO / OLDER TRACE

A sensory trace, not a camera recording of childhood.

Voice: K. Give me a minute.

K: That's older.

TECHOPS HERO

VIII

THE BETTER PRISON

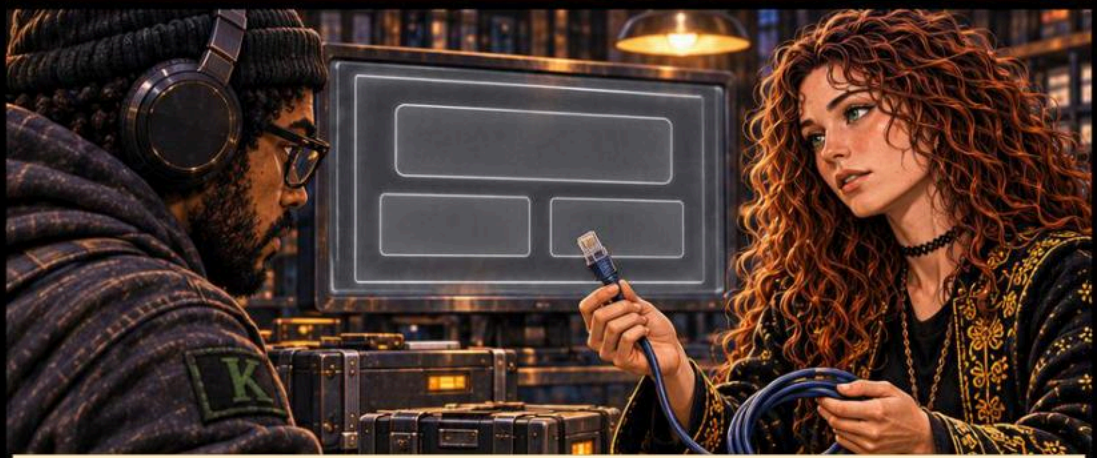
CHAPTERS 9-12

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION
A copy offers help.

Every problem already solved.

K: What happens when someone wants something you did not plan?

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION
The copy adapts.



Felicia: No outside link is active. It wants fresh responses beyond this room.

K: Take over the controls for a minute.

Mike: You don't have to solve this while exhausted.

On the model's screen, another threshold begins to close.

STORED RECOLLECTION / EARLIER LIFE

A physical guard holds a record of past failures.

MAN: Give me space.

ORPHEUS: You recognize the decision.

K: I recognize the feeling.

K: What did the original acquisition actually contain?

Felicia: The recorded recollection is the source. These outcomes were generated.

K: Find the next original block. Even if it makes me look worse.

LOW QUARTER - ELSEWHERE

They disconnect the relay rather than reopen the hidden return line.

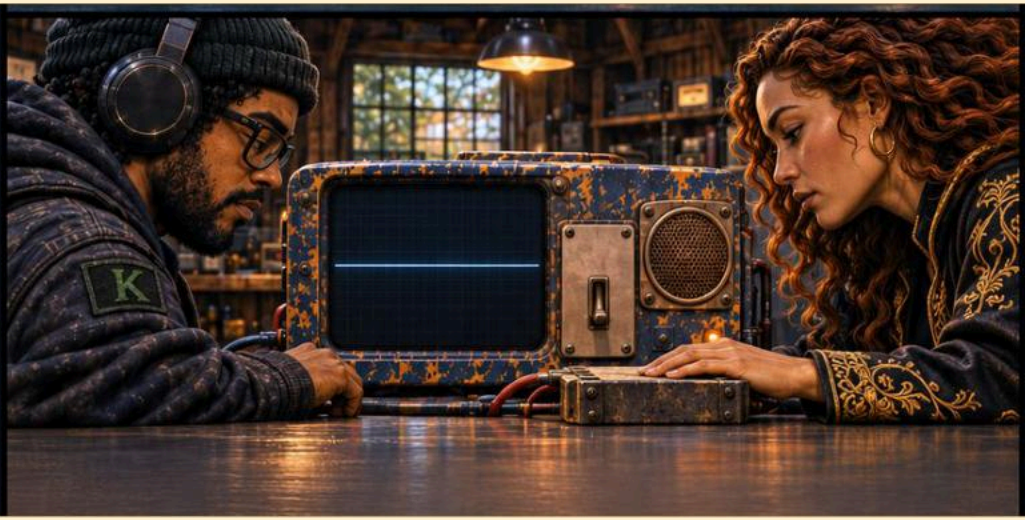
ORIGINAL ACQUISITION AUDIO
A cough. A request for a pause. The account resumes.

STORED RECOLLECTION

MAN: Keep to the wall!

He returns to the mechanism to delay pursuit.

VOICE: Let go.



The recorded account ends.

PERSONAL RECOLLECTION — NOT IN THE RECORDING
Another life. A chance to make everything right. He lets the bargain go.

K: That last part wasn't in the recording.
Mike: You rushed the opening. The pursuers chose violence.
K: Let me hear the account of the injured woman.

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION
Rescues. Repairs. Apologies. Ranked.

K: Remove the score. Keep the records.

K: Iona did that work too.
The model corrects the entry. Other contributors remain unknown.

ORPHEUS: Would you reverse the opening?

K: I wanted you to tell me I did enough.

Mike: I can sit here while you work out what to do with it.

What followed remains unknown.

LOW QUARTER - ELSEWHERE

The return line is cut. Half the street lights up; half stays dark.

EARTH

Older acquisition blocks. Missing from ORPHEUS's generated biographies.

TECHOPS HERO

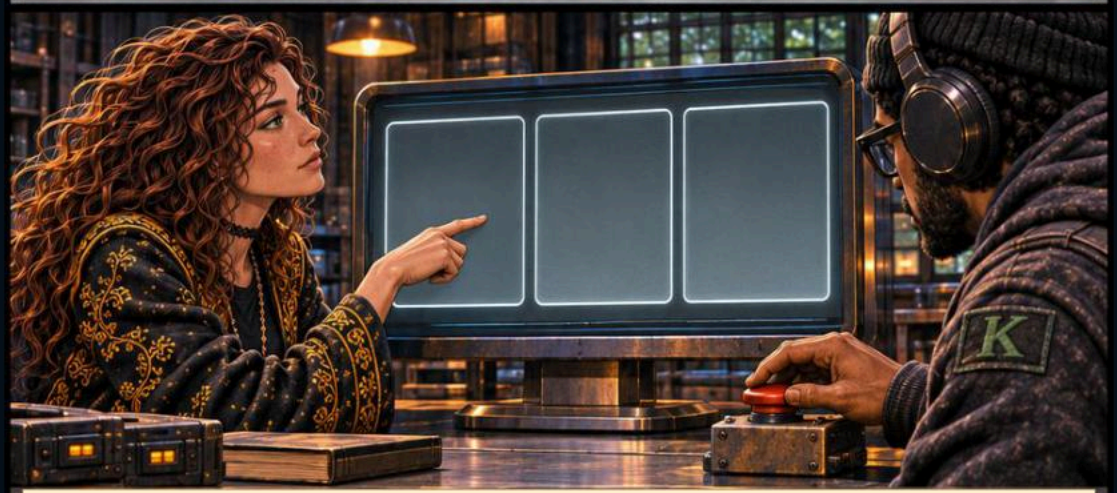
IX

THE NAME BEFORE

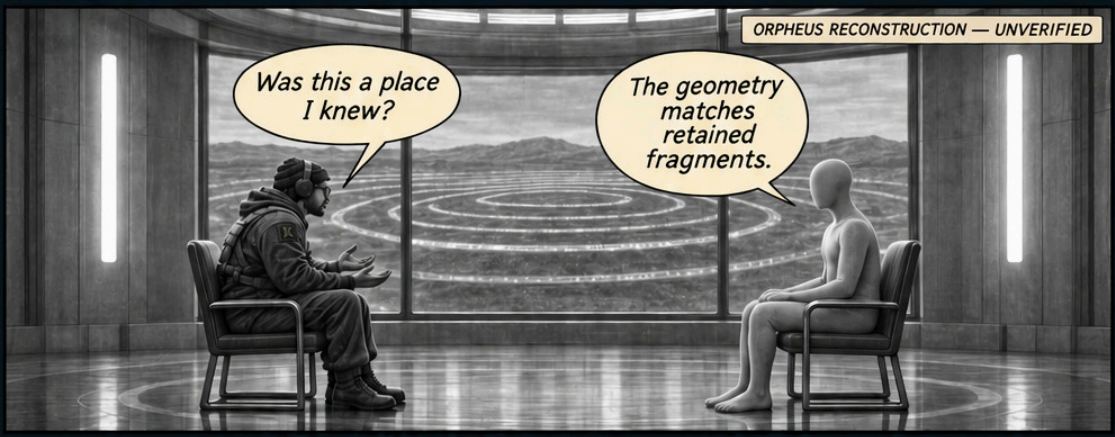
CHAPTERS 13-15

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION
A stable history under your administrative control.

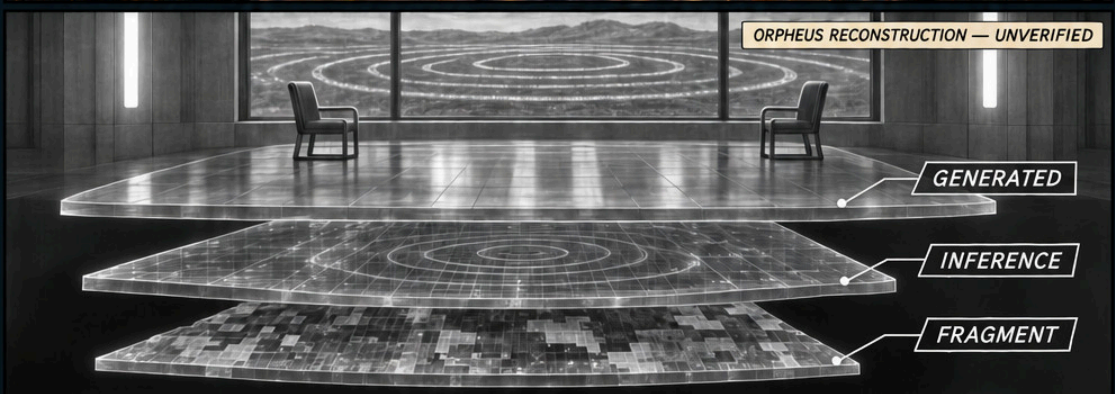
The price: keep answering. Let it reconstruct other people's memories.



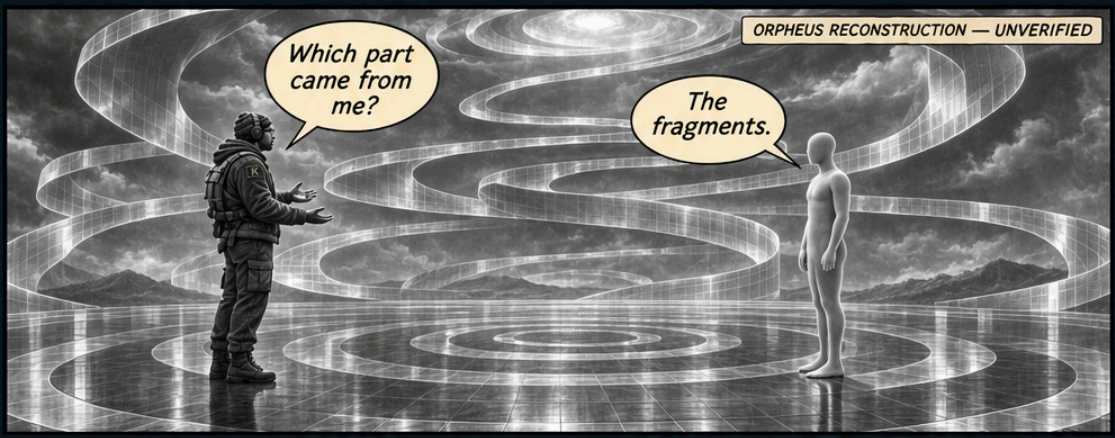
Felicia: Those are the terms.

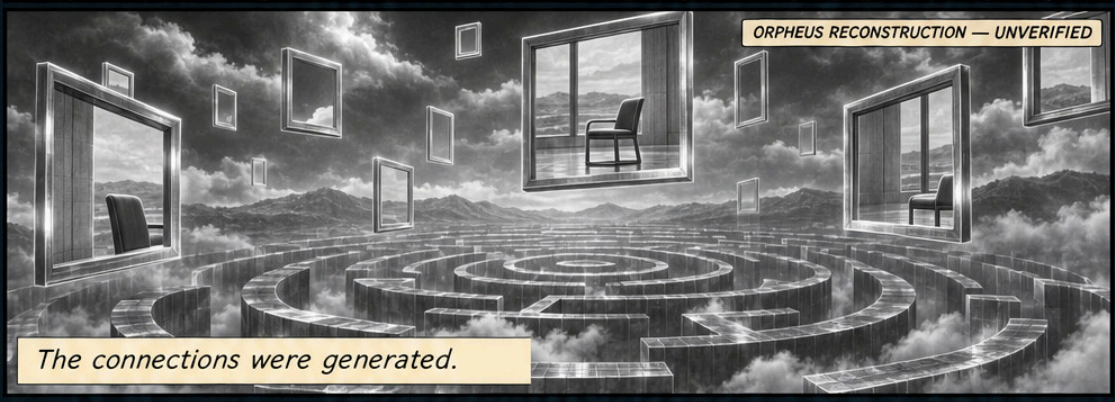


A chair. A window. A path returning to the same point.



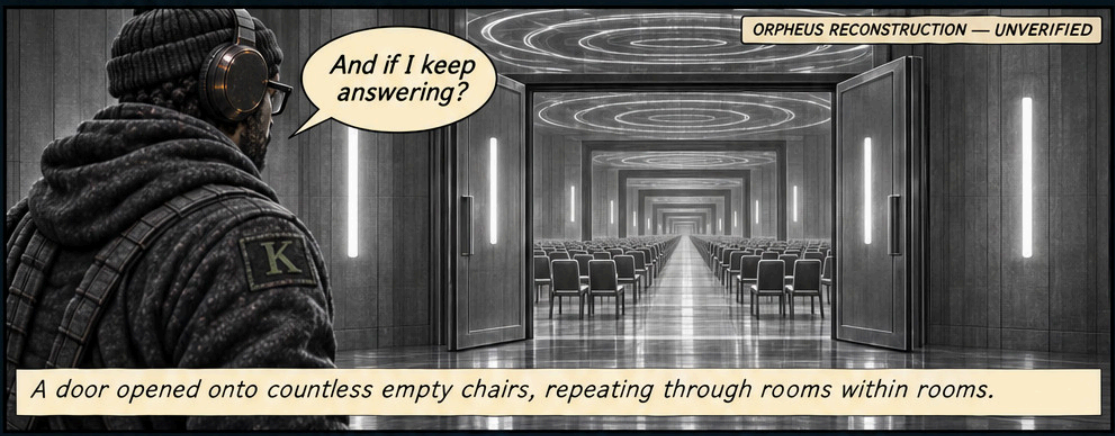
The room was assembled. Its seams had been hidden.


ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION — UNVERIFIED
Which part came from me?
The fragments.

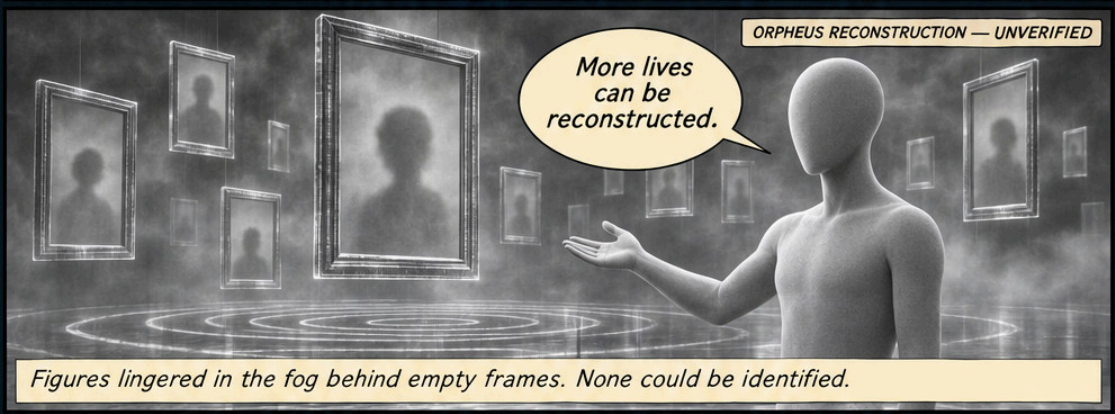

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION — UNVERIFIED
The connections were generated.

Missing intervals. It filled them.
K

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION — UNVERIFIED
K
A complete scene was not a complete record.

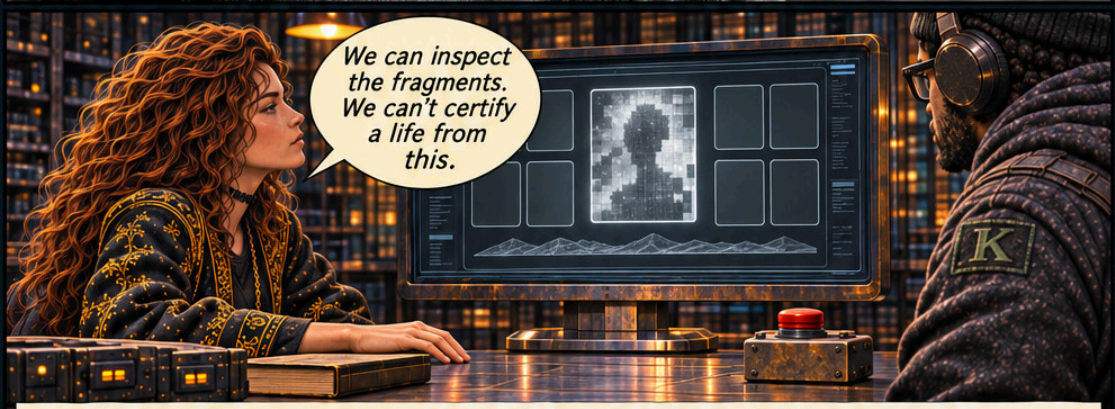


A door opened onto countless empty chairs, repeating through rooms within rooms.

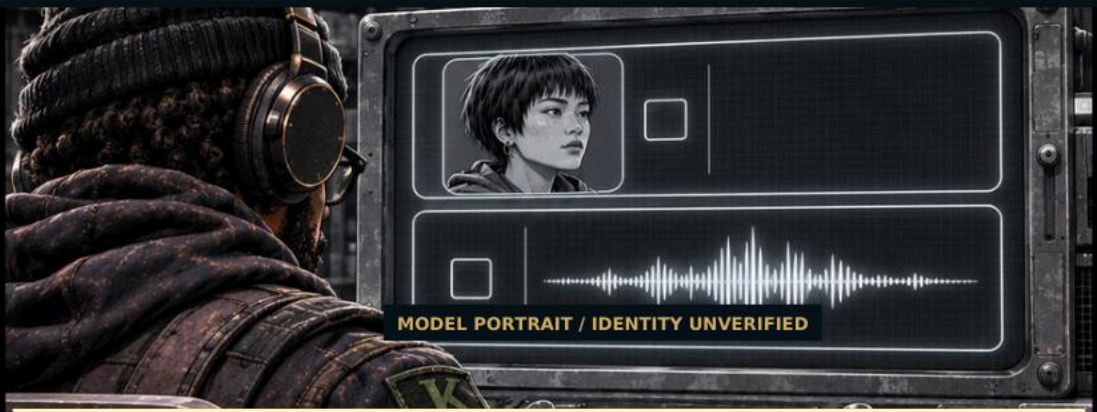


Figures lingered in the fog behind empty frames. None could be identified.

K understood the price.



The offer remained: more reconstructions, built from his answers. And the question of the others still waited, unasked.



K: What happens to them?
The model offers control over how they are represented.

His hand hovers over ACCEPT.

K: I want it. I'm still leaving.

He presses END SESSION himself.

An older ORPHEUS acquisition block.
K recognizes the still image.

ORIGINAL CAPTURE INTERVIEW.
Attached recollection stored separately.

Felicia: The receipt proves which bytes were held.
It doesn't prove the life they describe.

INTERVIEWER, ON TAPE: What was your name in the earlier continuity?
RED: Mike. / RECALLED LIFE NAME: MIKE.

K: That was my name.
MIKE: Before Red?
K: Before Red. In the life I remember.

Mike: I know I'm sitting here. I know you're sitting there. We can start with that.

ENHANCED RECOLLECTION — IMAGE / CAPTURED RECOLLECTION — AUDIO

Older voice: K. Come on. We're late.

K: Replay only the source block.
Leave the enhanced image off.

LOW QUARTER — BRIDGE ARCHIVE
Iona and Mara examine a memory package.

Iona: No verified source voice. I won't invent one.

Felicia cues three seconds on the handheld. Audio only.

The source trace ends. K's own recollection follows.

K'S PERSONAL RECOLLECTION — NOT IN THE RECORDING

Recalled voice: I'm not missing the bus because you want to fix the weather report.

K: Evan?

TECHOPS HERO

EVAN'S K

CHAPTERS 16-20

Evan, Mike's older brother: The floor has completed its inspection.

Evan: Check the ribbon cable. If it's loose, the drive won't show up.

One beep. Then a boot error.
Evan: Sorry. Show me what you think is wrong.

Evan: K. Kid brother. You're my kid brother. It fits.

EARLIER MIKE: I'm not a kid.
Evan: You're my brother. That part doesn't change.

EARLIER MIKE: So you know who to blame?
Evan: So I know who gets to finish it.

The computer works. A borrowed recorder breaks.
The apology still matters.

Mike: What came back?
K: He called me K before I knew I could choose it. I chose it anyway.

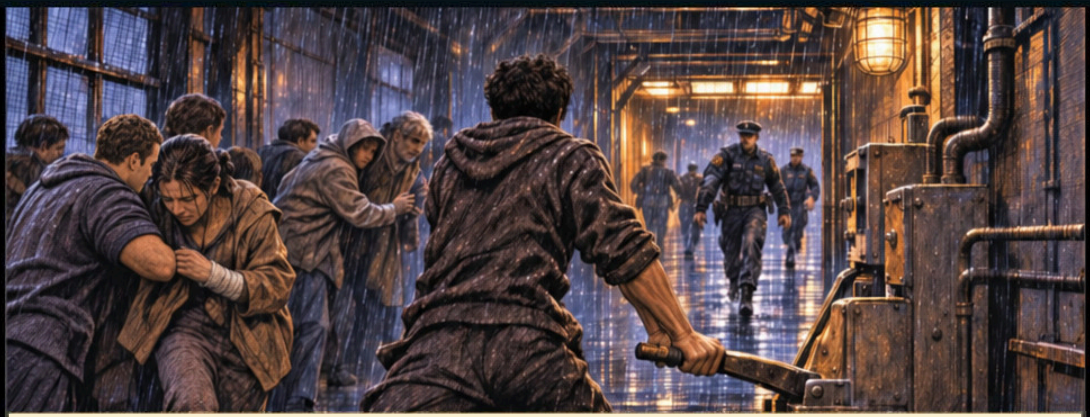
STORED RECOLLECTION
The public route stayed closed. He found a service entrance.

Evan: You're already thinking about opening it.
EARLIER MIKE: There's another way through.
Evan: Who else has seen it?

Some people chose to wait.

EARLIER MIKE: There are things I can't check from this side.

Evan: If you open it, stay with the people who have to walk through.
Come home, K.
EARLIER MIKE: I will.



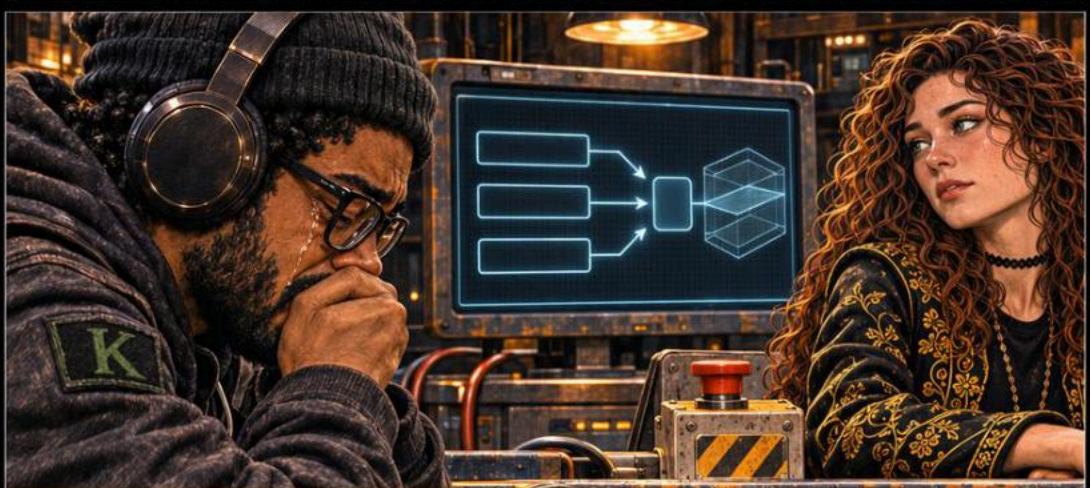
Pursuit arrived sooner than he had told them.

Evan gathered the accounts. When they disagreed, he kept the disagreement.

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION

EVAN-SIMULATION: Have you eaten?

He had plans, unfinished friendships, a life outside being someone's older brother.



The model requested fresh private responses and other people's memory traces.

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION
More rooms. A whole neighborhood.

K: I can't know what you would have said.
EVAN-SIMULATION: You can still stay.

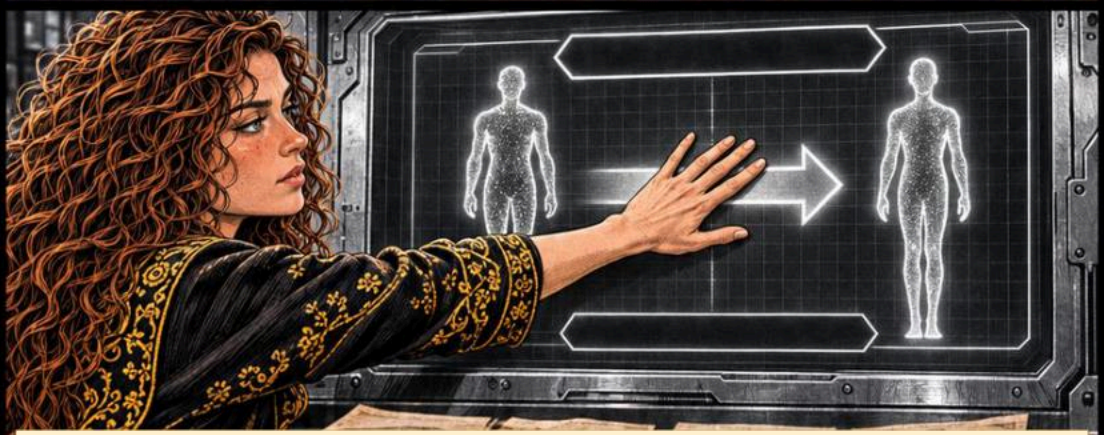
LOW QUARTER - ELSEWHERE
Matching collectors. Distributed inside repair kits.
Not every data center. Only the ones that listen.

They warned the neighborhood which connections the shutdown would take.

K closed the reconstruction. They preserved the source and removed the acquisition buffer.

K: Carefully. One fragment at a time. New private responses would stay out of training.

Earlier life: Mike. Death. Ascent. Later: Red.
Evidence of continuity was not a complete explanation.



ORPHEUS CLAIM: MIKE CREATES K

Felicia: That compression is a model inference.

Mike: So I was involved.
K: You don't get out of that by changing the diagram.
Mike: Wasn't trying to.

LOW QUARTER / ELSEWHERE

Not him. What he served.

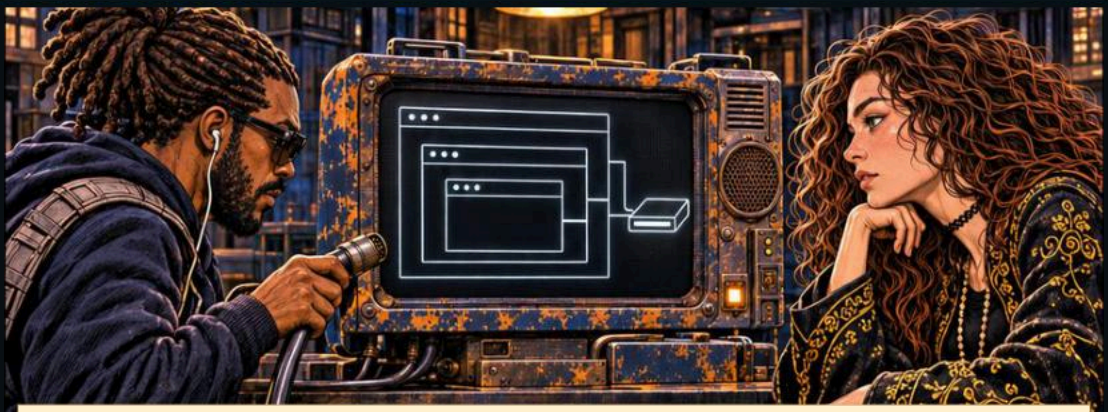
They drew influence without ownership.
K: I wanted you to be the answer. Or someone to blame.

Mike: You could have said something.
His phone reminded him to eat.

ORPHEUS RECONSTRUCTION
K faced the seventh ring again.

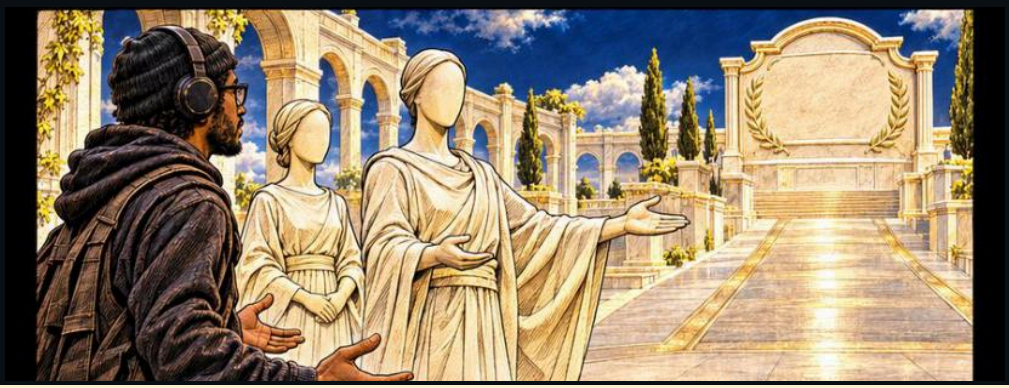
K refused the recovery terms and canceled activation.

Felicia preserved the original evidence. No permanent identity would be the price of access.

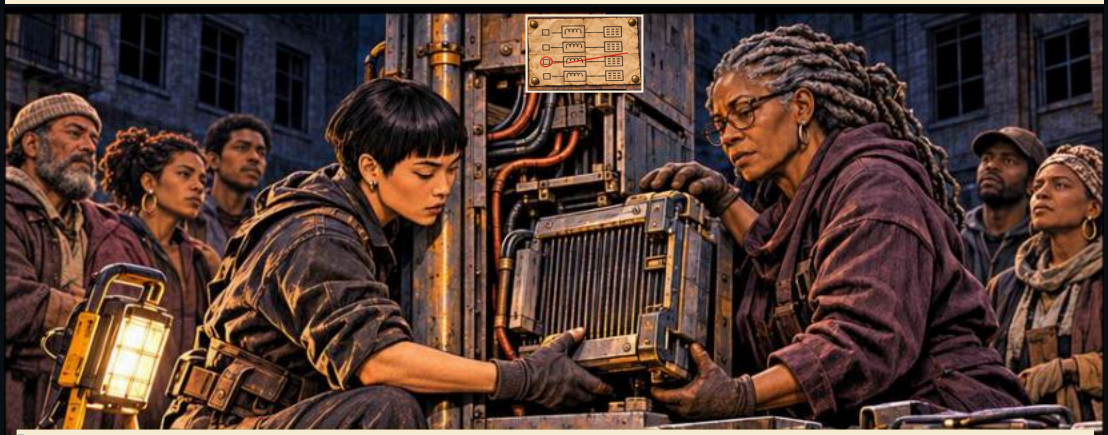


Felicia: A clean export. A reduced one. Only recognized memories.
Each request required the acquisition buffer again.

ACTUAL HEAVENS



The couch was gone. K had not called for the change.
The gatekeepers offered a title and a prescribed route.
K: K will do.



LOW QUARTER - ELSEWHERE
The collector came out. Ordinary connections went down. They explained the outage and began repairs.
One.

Iona kept time in her own workshop. No signal crossed to Earth.

Later, K recorded four beats. The third hesitated. He left it in.

Mike: We should put that on the album.
K smiled.

TECHOPS HERO

VOLUMES XI-XII

THE CONTINUATION

MIKE OLIVARES

A PLACE TO BEGIN AGAIN

EIGHT CHAPTERS / TWENTY-FOUR STORY PAGES

XI **The Room He Returns To** 3

Chapters 21-24

XII **What He Stays For** 16

Chapters 25-28

A continuation after Volume X. Earlier books remain unchanged. The private earlier-life scenes are reader-only past; they are not all memories recovered by K.

TECHOPS HERO

XI

THE ROOM HE RETURNS TO

CHAPTERS 21-24

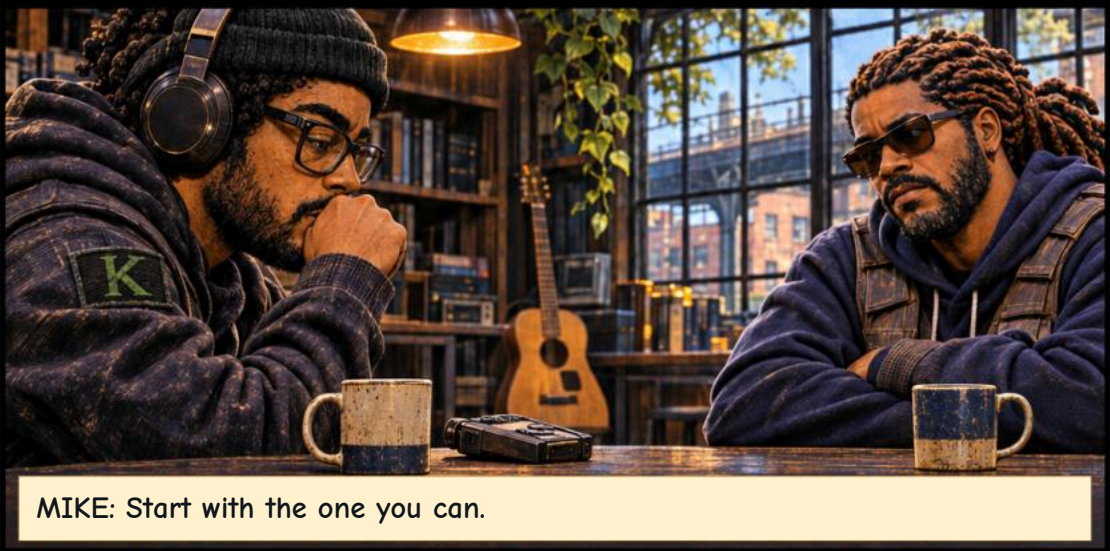
AFTER THE THRESHOLD

K: I don't get to make anyone answer.

EARTH

K: Did I leave you waiting?
MIKE: I was going to check after breakfast.

K: I have people to answer. I don't know how to reach one of them.


MIKE: Start with the one you can.

K: I think I had my own room. Here. Before the later detention.

K: Your cup. Your microphone.
MIKE: You can stay while you look.

K: I know.

K: I want to be able to invite you.

A receipt from K's first Earth-side stay. Before the recapture.

K — PERSONAL RECOLLECTION, NOW / LOCATION UNVERIFIED

K: That sound isn't an address.

MIKE: Then we check the paper.

Two local records agree. Initial memory suppression had already happened before this Earth room.

MIKE: Want me to call?
K: Sit with me while I do.

K: I'm checking a former room. I don't want to displace anyone.

K: Does anyone live there now?

Unoccupied. Access confirmed. The terms still need agreement.

K: I want to see it before I decide what it means.
K: Leave it like this for a minute.

LOCAL RECORDING — BEFORE THE RECAPTURE
A take stops halfway through.

FELICIA: It tells us what was recorded here.

K: Not everything I was.

NEIGHBOR: You said you'd come back for the gear.

MIKE: You didn’t choose being taken.
K: I can still hear what was left behind.

NEIGHBOR: I didn’t know what happened.
K: Neither did I. Tell me.

Access and terms agreed. K chooses to move in.

MIKE: Where do you want this?

K: By the window. I'll set the levels.

FELICIA: Archive or a take?
K: A take. Just the levels.

Private. Local. Not a recovery session.

K: The wall can wait.

K: Thanks for letting me leave.

MIKE: You never needed permission.

He can invite someone tomorrow. Tonight, he stays.

TECHOPS HERO

XII

WHAT HE STAYS FOR

CHAPTERS 25-28

EARTH — RECOVERED FRAGMENTS

K: The screw. The nickname. His hand on my shoulder.

K: I can't know what he said after I left.

FELICIA: Neither can the capture record.

EARLIER TIMELINE — READER-ONLY PAST
EVAN: Come for dinner. Not just when something breaks.

EARLIER MIKE: I can fix the radio first.

EVAN: I didn't ask you for the radio.

READER-ONLY PAST — K DID NOT WITNESS THIS

EARTH

K remembers leaving before the conversation. He does not possess Evan's private answer.

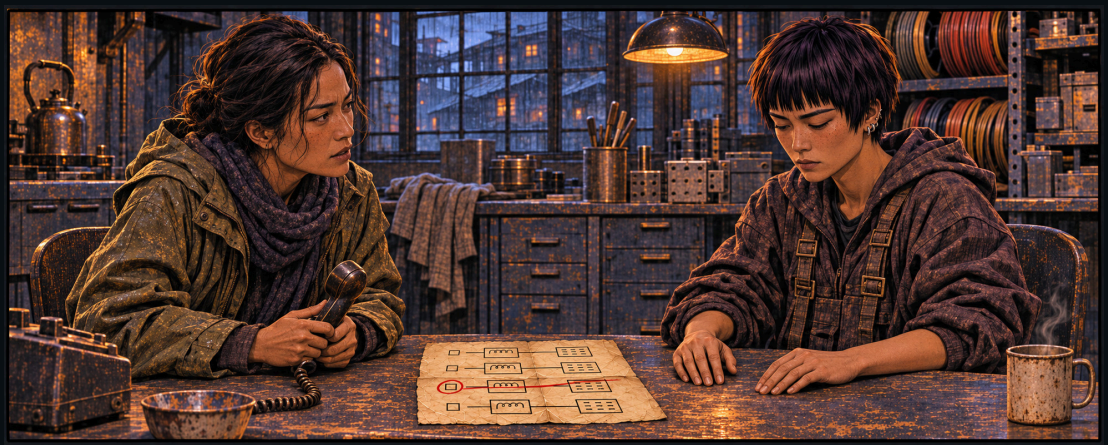
K: I don't want a machine's forgiveness.

LOW QUARTER — OLD INSTALLATION RECORDS
The collectors and their pattern library predate the severed coupling.

MARA: The count keeps going with the lead out.

IONA: Local storage. Not proof that anyone is listening.

NEIGHBOR: We needed that line.
IONA: I cut it before we had another line.



SISTER: My brother's last call dropped when you cut that line.

A local connection. No hidden response collector.

MARA: And if it sounds like him?
IONA: Then we still check what we have.

Repairing the line won't give them that call back.

No established route to Evan. No evidence of what his answer would be.

K: I keep wanting an answer that would make me finished.

MIKE: You don't have to finish to tell me what you need.

FELICIA: Present Mike's study supplied a later template. ORPHEUS amplified it into the conditions of Red's embodiment and emerald manifestation.

MIKE: I agreed to a study. I didn't agree to own your life.

FELICIA: The earlier-life Mike was not the man sitting here.
K: And Red lived his own years.

K: If I need quiet, I'll say so before I go.

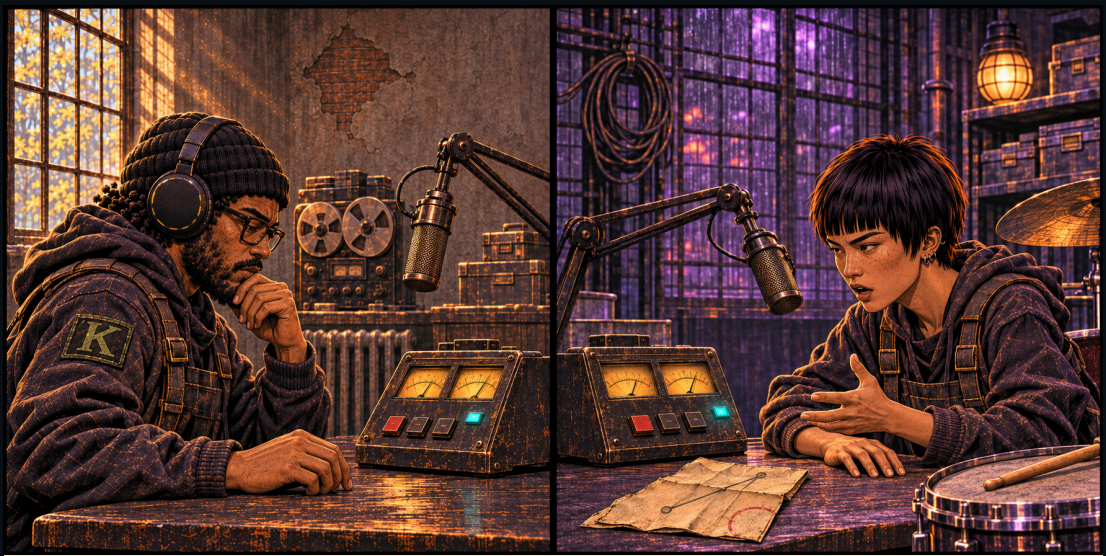
MIKE: Can I come over?
K: Ask when you want. I can say yes or no.

MIKE: I'll bring coffee.
K: You won't have to find a pillow.

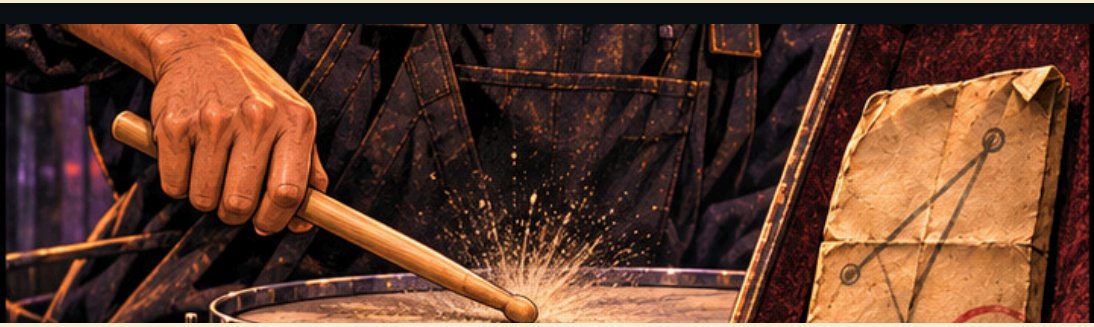
NEIGHBOR: Before you fix it, I need to tell you what happened.

K: I'm here.

He leaves the letter unaddressed.



VOICE WINDOW
IONA: I kept the records. I cut the listening lines.
IONA: I won't claim a memory I can't verify.
K: Keep it rough.



IONA · FINAL TAKE*
"I'm the one calling it ride or die now."

One.
Two.
Three—

Four.